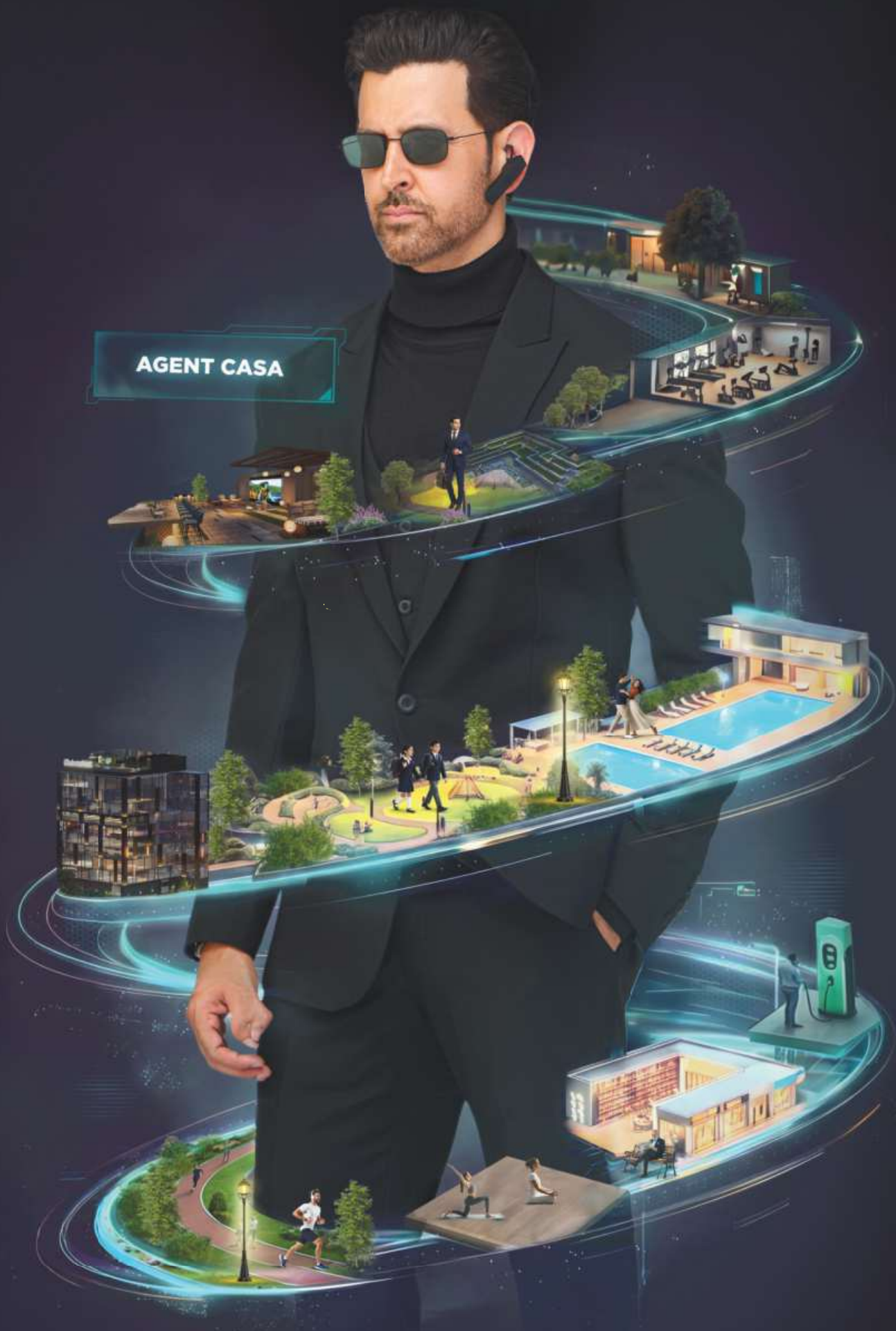




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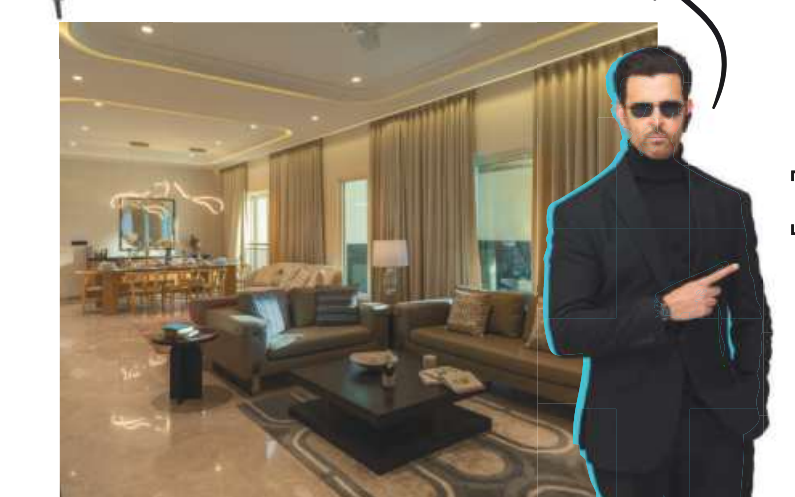
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Intelligent design,
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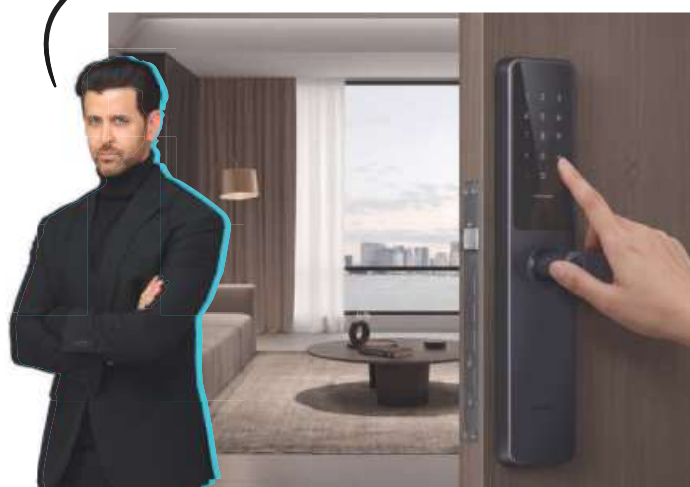


- Premium Italian Marble Flooring
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Prime Location. Unmatched Value!



Every unit packs in High-end
Specifications

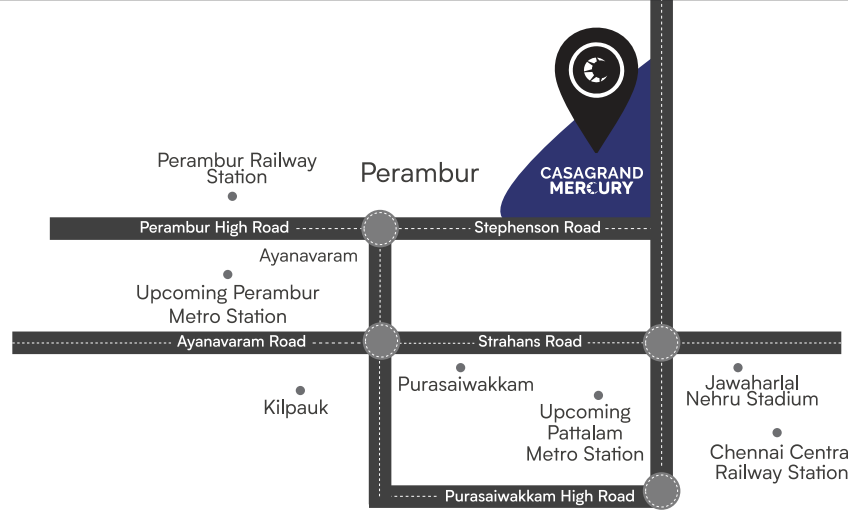


- Upcoming Metro Station - 1 Km
- Purasaiwakkam - 1 Km
- Kilpauk - 2 Km
- Egmore - 3 Km
- Chennai Central Station - 4 Km
- Anna Nagar - 5 Km

NEIGHBOURHOOD PRICING

LOCATION	MARKET PRICE
Egmore	₹ 20,000/sft.
Kilpauk	₹ 19,000/sft.
Anna Nagar	₹ 18,000/sft.
Purasaiwakkam	₹ 13,000/sft.

LOCATION MAP





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FITNESS?

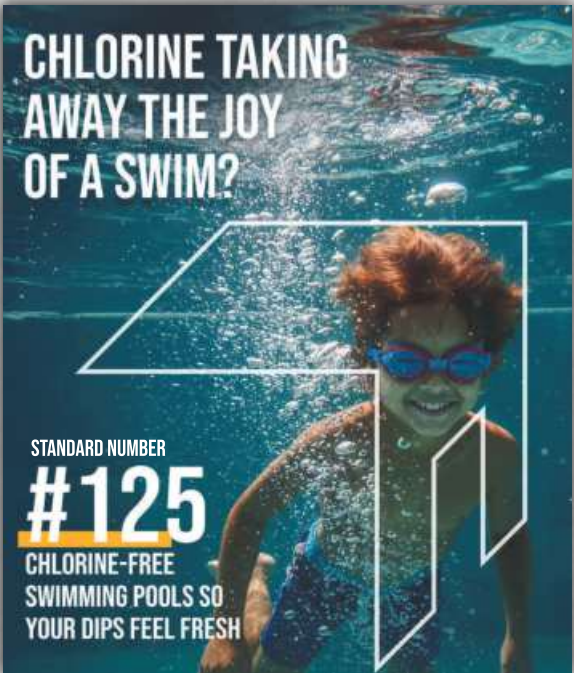


STANDARD NUMBER

#112

OUTDOOR CROSSFIT COURTS
WITH FRESH AIR, VITAMIN D,
AND A NATURAL SEROTONIN
BOOST

CHLORINE TAKING
AWAY THE JOY
OF A SWIM?



STANDARD NUMBER

#125

CHLORINE-FREE
SWIMMING POOLS SO
YOUR DIPS FEEL FRESH

UNINTERRUPTED
CALLS IN THE LIFT?



STANDARD NUMBER

#39

SIGNAL BOOSTERS
BECAUSE SOME
CONNECTIONS SHOULDN'T
BE CUT SHORT

THINKING ABOUT
UPGRADING TO
AN EV?



STANDARD NUMBER

#115

EV CAR CHARGING STATIONS,
SO YOU CAN MAKE THAT
CLEAN ENERGY SWITCH

IS YOUR KIDS' PLAYTIME
INTERRUPTED
BY TRAFFIC?



STANDARD NUMBER

#02

VEHICLE-FREE
PODIUM MADE FOR
PLAY, NOT PARKING

PLAYTIME
WITHOUT A
LEASH?



STANDARD NUMBER

#116

PET PARK WITH A WASH
STATION, SO YOUR PET CAN
RUN AND SPLASH FREELY.

FEELING
BOXED
IN?



STANDARD NUMBER

#23

70% OPEN GREEN
SPACES, SO LIFE FEELS
FRESH EVERYDAY

MORE HOOPS,
MORE EXCITEMENT?



STANDARD NUMBER

#114

A MULTI-HOOP BASKETBALL
COURT MEANS MORE PLAY,
MORE ENERGY, AND
NO WAITING FOR TURNS

WHAT IF YOU
COULD ESCAPE INTO
A FOREST, BUT AT HOME?



STANDARD NUMBER

#133

NATURE WALKWAYS,
SO YOU CAN UNWIND IN
THE LAP OF GREENERY

WANT TO WATCH
A MOVIE UNDER
THE STARS?



STANDARD NUMBER

#146

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FOR A SURREAL VIEWING
EXPERIENCE

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THAT FEELS LIKE
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CASAGRAN
building aspirations

*Based on CBRE report 2024
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STANDING STRONG
Ladakhis serve as first line of defence: Shah
NEWS » PAGE 10

PEAK DEMAND
Coal, solar to power India as temperatures rise
NEWS » PAGE 12



NARCOTICS RING BUSTED
NCB seizes 349 kg cocaine in Mumbai
NEWS » PAGE 11

POLICING THE FEED
Far from a safe harbour
Critics, comedians, and media face blocking orders, legal scrutiny
GROUND ZERO » PAGE 9



THOMAS CUP
Lakshya, Ayush power India into semifinals
SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY



‘Hard work of DMK cadre will yield results’

CHENNAI
Due to the hard work of DMK cadre in the run-up to the Assembly election, the party will secure the desired result on counting day on May 4, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin said in Chennai on Friday. » **PAGE 6**

Two booked for abetment of suicide

CHENNAI
Two constables of the Chennai police and three others were booked by the Rajasthan police on the charge of abetment of suicide, sources said on Friday. » **PAGE 6**

METROPLUS WEEKEND » 6 PAGES
PROPERTYPLUS » 10 PAGES

Commercial LPG, 5-kg cylinders to cost more

Price of commercial LPG hiked by ₹993 a cylinder and that of 5-kg cylinder by ₹261; price of ATF for international carriers raised; govt. also reduces excise duty on export of diesel, aviation fuel

Saptarnno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Oil marketing companies (OMCs) on Friday sharply hiked the price of commercial LPG by ₹993 per cylinder and that of 5-kg free trade LPG by ₹261 per cylinder. Further, the price of bulk diesel was raised from ₹137 to ₹149 per litre.

Whilst the OMCs did not hike the price of LPG meant for domestic usage and that of aviation turbine fuel (ATF) for domestic scheduled carriers, the price of ATF for international airlines has been pushed up by \$76.55 per kilolitre from \$1,435 per kilolitre.

The prices of retail petrol and diesel are unchanged.

In a separate move, the



Fuel crisis: Commercial LPG cylinder delivery workers unload cylinders from a truck at a distribution centre. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

Ministry of Finance reduced the excise duty on the export of diesel to ₹23 for every litre from ₹55.5 per litre and that of ATF to ₹33 per litre from ₹42 per litre, whilst the special additional excise duty (SAED) on the export of petrol continues to remain nil. The previous revision to

the excise duties on the export of diesel and ATF was done on April 11. The government said that the earlier upward revisions were to ensure the availability of these products in the domestic market and cushion against any impact on supplies. A reduction in the duty on exports is thus a

Congress slams government on hike in LPG rates

NEW DELHI
The Congress on Friday slammed the Narendra Modi government over the latest price hike for commercial LPG cylinders, with Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi calling it the “bill for elections”. » **PAGE 11**

change in that stance.

Whilst the prices of domestic LPG being unchanged offer respite, the steep hike in prices of commercial LPG and that of 5-kg free trade LPG raise concerns.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

GST revenue hits record ₹2.43 lakh crore in April

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The government’s Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue in April 2026 surged to an all-time high of ₹2.43 lakh crore, up 8.7% over April last year. Growth was once again driven by collections on imports, with revenue from domestic sales growing slower.

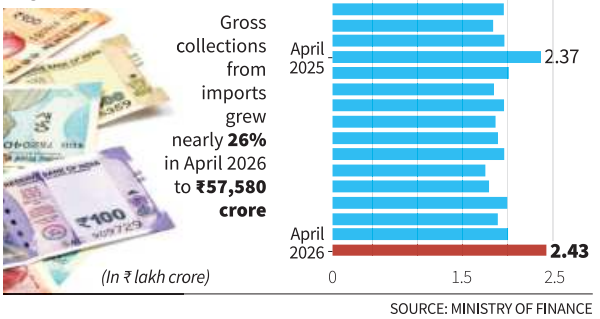
Tax experts, however, note that collections in April, which represent activity in March, typically come in higher as both industry and the tax administration make a final push to achieve the financial year-end targets.

Data show that there has been a record collection every April ever since the GST was rolled out in 2017, except for April 2020, which was impacted by the COVID-19 pandemic and the lockdown.

“April 2026 GST collections cap off a resilient FY26 for the GST regime,

April highs

The April GST intake reached **₹2.43 lakh crore**, marking the third consecutive year of record highs for the month



with gross revenues rising 8.7% year-on-year to about ₹2.43 lakh crore compared to April 2025, despite continued global uncertainty and West Asia-related geopolitical headwinds,” Mahesh Jaising, partner & indirect tax leader at Deloitte India, said.

The data show that net collections, once refunds are accounted for, stood at ₹2.11 lakh crore in April 2026, up 7.3% over April

last year. Notably, the data also show that the growth in collections was once again driven by imports.

Gross collections from imports grew nearly 26% in April 2026 to ₹57,580 crore. Collections from domestic sales grew at 4.3% to ₹1.85 lakh crore in the period.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Trump ‘not satisfied’ with Iran’s peace bid

Stanly Johny

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Friday he was “not satisfied” with Iran’s latest proposal in negotiations to end the war between the countries, rejecting the plan almost as soon as it was delivered.

Tehran delivered the new proposal for talks with the U.S. via Pakistan, which is acting as a mediator between the two sides, even as the Revolutionary Guards warned that American warships “will burn” like U.S. bases in the region, if Iran is attacked again.

The text of the proposal was handed to Pakistan on Thursday evening, state-run Islamic Republic News

Agency reported on Friday.

“Ending the war and establishing a sustainable peace remain Tehran’s main priorities in negotiations with the U.S.,” Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei said in a TV interview.

“They want to make a deal, I’m not satisfied with it, so we’ll see what happen,” Mr. Trump told presspersons on Friday at the White House, Associated Press reported. He did not elaborate on what he saw as the latest proposal’s shortcomings. “They’re asking for things I can’t agree to,” he said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Watery grave



Rescue workers, including NDRF personnel, conduct operations to recover an overturned cruise boat at the Bargi Dam in Jabalpur district of Madhya Pradesh on Friday. Nine bodies have been recovered, while four persons remain missing. PTI (REPORT ON PAGES 6&12)

SC to hear Trinamool plea against EC today

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A Special Bench of the Supreme Court is scheduled to urgently hear a petition from the Trinamool Congress on Saturday. The petition challenges a Calcutta High Court decision from April 30, which had dismissed their challenge to an Election Commission order on April 13, mandating that at least one counting supervisor and assistant at each counting table for the West Bengal Assembly elections must be a Central government or Central Public Sector Unit employee.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Joyimalya Bagchi will hear the petition as the counting of

votes for West Bengal election is scheduled for May 4.

The communication insisting on the presence of Central government employees at every counting table was issued by the Additional Chief Electoral Officer, West Bengal, who is arraigned as a respondent in the petition along with the Election Commission.

The High Court had refused to entertain the petition filed by West Bengal’s ruling party, invoking the bar under Article 329(b), which mandated that no election to Parliament or State Legislatures could be questioned except through an election petition.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

T.N. to experience hotter May, with above-normal rainfall

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu will experience above-normal maximum and minimum temperatures in May, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said in its outlook released on Friday. However, above-normal rainfall could bring some respite to the State, it added.

The IMD outlined the likely impact of increased temperatures, including on agriculture, and issued an agromet advisory.

The State’s coastal region so far as the Cauvery delta districts is expected to record three-five heat-wave days.

Sizzling weather had scorched the State in April

The IMD has said the temperature may remain above average in most parts of the State

and the IMD said mercury levels may remain above average in most parts of the State this month, except in some Western Ghats districts.

Nights may be warmer as the minimum temperature may increase above normal levels.

The IMD has warned of the likely impact of heat-wave conditions and urged the authorities to take preparedness measures. Early warnings and impact-based forecasts will be issued on heatwave condi-

tions. A heatwave is declared when a place experiences a temperature that is four to five degrees Celsius above the average daytime temperature.

V.R. Durai, Director, Regional Weather Forecasting Centre, Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC), said the coastal belt alone would experience hot and humid weather conditions. North coastal districts close to Andhra Pradesh might record three to five heatwave days.

Daytime heating and convective activity might influence above-average rainfall in the State, which usually receives 66.3 mm of rain in May.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

Four-year-old gets trapped in parked car, dies in Karur

The Hindu Bureau
KARUR

A four-year-old boy died of suffocation after he accidentally got himself locked in a parked car near his house at Kazhugur, near Kulithalai, in Karur district on Thursday.

The deceased, identified as Sanjeevi, was the son of Velu, 36, a construction worker, and Mariswari, 30. Police sources said that as he did not return home for long, his parents started a search and found him unconscious in the car. He was rushed to the Government District Headquarters Hospital, Kulithalai, where he was declared brought dead.

SC grants anticipatory bail to Congress leader in case filed by Assam CM’s wife

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has granted Congress leader Pawan Khera anticipatory bail in a criminal case instituted on a complaint filed by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma’s wife, saying the case appears to be motivated by political rivalry and does not warrant custodial interrogation.

A Bench headed by Justice J.K. Maheshwari cautioned the State of Assam against using the power to arrest so casually, as if to strike a blow at a political rival. The 22-page order said the right to personal liberty cannot be jeopardised lightly. The order was published on May 1.

“Criminal process must be applied with objectivity and circumspection so as to ensure that individual liberty is not imperiled by proceedings that may be coloured by political rivalry. We are further of the opinion that the allegations and counter-allegations, as apparent in the present case, prima facie, appear to be politically motivated and seemingly influenced by such rivalry, rather than disclosing a situation warranting custodial interrogation, and the veracity of the allegations can be tested at trial,” the Supreme Court Bench, also comprising Justice Atul S. Chandurkar, observed in the order.

The court said shackling a cherished fundamental



Pawan Khera

right like personal liberty should be justified at a higher threshold than what seemed to be political rivalry.

Mr. Khera had accused Mr. Sarma’s wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, of holding three passports of Egypt, the UAE, and Antigua and Barbuda. He had stated that two of these nations were “Muslim coun-

tries, however, the husband’s politics is based on hatred against the Muslim community in the State”. He had also exhibited documents stating that she had a company registered in the U.S. with an investment of more than ₹50,000 crores, besides owning assets in Dubai.

Mr. Khera had stated that Mr. Sarma’s election affidavit had not disclosed any of these details of wealth.

The FIR was registered by the Assam Police after Ms. Sharma denied the veracity of these documents and stated that they were fabricated with forged seals and QR codes.

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» PAGE 10

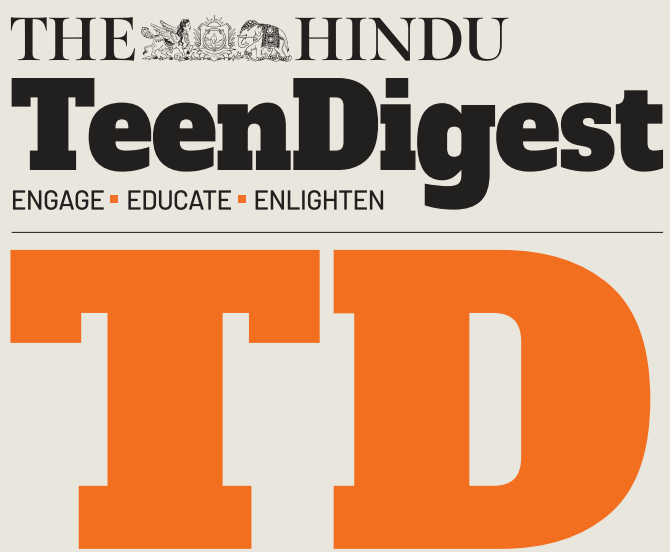


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M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Robotics centre established at Easwari Engineering College

A Global Excellence Center for Robotics was set up at SRM Group's Easwari Engineering College by Switzerland-based ABB Robotics on Friday. This is the third such robotics centre in the world to be established by ABB Robotics. The centre features advanced AI-enabled robotic systems and intelligent automation labs, including 3D pin picking. The setup integrates autonomous mobile robots, generative AI, vision systems, digital twin technologies, and smart manufacturing solutions. The centre will provide college students with hands-on experience in AI and robotics.

Rotary Club, Right Hospitals to open dialysis centre

A new dialysis facility will be inaugurated at Kilpauk on May 3, expanding access to affordable renal care. The centre, set up by the Rotary Club of Chennai Suncity, in collaboration with Right Hospitals, will offer advanced dialysis services with a focus on safety and hygiene. The inauguration will be led by R.S. Munirathinam, and attended by Rotary district officials.

IIT-M reports sharp rise in blackbuck population on campus over six years

It increased from 12 in 2021 to 77 in 2026; IIT-Madras took stricter measures such as reducing speed limits on campus after wildlife casualties were reported in 2024; targeted measures, including removal of fences, control of stray dog population, and closure of wells helped stabilise population

ECO WATCH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Indian Institute of Technology Madras (IIT-M) has reported a rise in its blackbuck population from 12 in 2021 to 77 in 2026.

The institute's 611-acre campus, which is a part of the Guindy National Park ecosystem, once saw blackbuck numbers decline sharply – from several hundred in the 1980s to fewer than 20 in 2003.

Targeted measures over the years, including removal of fences in academic zones, control of stray dog population, and closure of open wells and pits, helped stabilise the population at 21 by 2009.

The increase in recent years was announced by Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan in a recent social media post.

Blackbucks, which pref-



Stepping up safety: Blackbucks, which prefer open grasslands with patches of taller vegetation for breeding and protection, are highly sensitive to environmental pressures and territorial disturbances. FILE PHOTO

er open grasslands with patches of taller vegetation for breeding and protection, are highly sensitive to environmental pressures and territorial disturbances.

Campus planning at IIT-M has increasingly factored in these ecological

needs through regulated land use and habitat protection.

Following wildlife casualties reported in 2024, the institute introduced stricter measures to prevent further harm. Speed limits on campus were re-

duced to 20 kmph, with penalties for violations. Vehicles involved in injuring wildlife face fines of up to ₹1 lakh and seizure.

An IIT-M spokesperson said the institute had created four acres of open space by removing *Prosopis juli-*

flora and paved the way for a grassland, benefiting the blackbucks. Landscaping efforts incorporate indigenous plant species, reducing water requirements by up to 40% compared to non-native plants.

In addition to the en-

dangered blackbuck, the campus continues to provide an ideal habitat for 298 plant species and 35 animal species, the spokesperson said. It also attracts 51 species each of birds and butterflies and is home to about 250 spotted deer.

Green Committee

He added that the institute's 'Green Committee', an initiative launched in 2023 to bring about sustainable change within its campus and beyond, aims at developing and implementing a comprehensive Climate Action Plan tailored to the unique needs of the campus.

A Forest Department official said the recovery of the blackbuck population shows the importance of sustained habitat management in urban ecosystems, where even small changes in land use, traffic regulation, and predator control can significantly influence the survival and breeding of sensitive species.

Three persons drown in two separate incidents

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 15-year-old boy was among two persons who drowned in a lake in Pallikaranai on Friday.

A senior official from the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said one of the deceased, Perumal, was a resident of Sengazhanni Amman Kovil Street near Narayanapuram lake in Pallikaranai. On Friday morning, he, along with

Perumal died while trying to rescue his 15-year-old grandson from drowning in a lake in Pallikaranai

his grandsons, Bharath and Dinesh, went to bathe in the lake.

While Perumal was bathing, Bharath ventured into a deeper part of the lake and lost his footing. Perumal tried to rescue

him but got trapped in the mud, and subsequently, drowned.

On seeing them struggling to get out of the water, Dinesh, who was standing on the bank of the lake, called for help. Residents near the lake rushed to their rescue. While they retrieved the body of Perumal, they could not find Bharath.

Search under way
The Pallikaranai police,

along with personnel from the Medavakkam Fire and Rescue Services station, launched a rescue operation.

In a separate incident, Aravind Prakash, 31, of Pammal, drowned in the Kosasthalaiair near Minjur.

A police official said Prakash, who was working as a collection agent for a private finance company, had gone for a swim with his friends at the Seemavaram checkdam near Min-

jur in Tiruvallur district. While swimming, he ventured into the deeper portion of the river and drowned.

Body retrieved

The Minjur police and the fire and rescue services personnel from Ponneri station retrieved the body from the river.

The police later sent the body to Stanley Government Hospital for a post-mortem.

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NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS

No: 52265080 Date: 27.04.2026

"THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT TENDERS"

Sr.DMM/NWR/AJMER acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites E-tenders on www.irops.gov.in site as follows. E- Tender will be closed at 11.05.2026 14:30 Hrs.

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Tender Notice No	Tender Description	Amendment as	Tender Opening date
1	52265080	DT 26.03.26	Supply, Installation & Commissioning of IoT Based Water Level Indicator System	Prototype Approval Plan (Annexure-A) clause added in tender as per RDSO Specifications. For details, please refer to IREPS website.	11.05.2026 at 14:30 Hrs.

Note (1) Interested tenderers may visit the website irops.gov.in for full details/ description/Specification/EMD & tender cost etc. All tenderers are requested to obtain digital signatures and get them registered on above site and quote electronically only. (2) For viewing and participating in other tenders such as open tender costing below Rs. 50 Lakh, limited tenders, special limited tenders and low value tenders, please visit www.irops.gov.in.

621-PS/26 Sr. Divisional Material Manager, Ajmer

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS

TENDER NOTICE No: 5/2026/18 Date:27.04.2026

The Principal Chief Material Manager, North Western Railway, Headquarter Jaipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-tenders on www.irops.gov.in site as follows.

Sr.No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Unit	Due date
1.	20261693	Suspension Tube for WAG-9 and WAP 7	50	Nos	15.05.2026
2.	40251832A	DISCONNECTING AND EARTHING DEVICE, 8-POLE, 2-WAY	214	Nos	20.05.2026
3	20261402	Air Compressor [Main] with motor	10	Nos	20.05.2026
4	10251614A	COIL SOLENOID	562	Nos	29.05.2026
5	6325ENG40	Manufacture and supply of 6.0 mm thick Nylon Cord Reinforced Grooved Rubber Sole Plates (Pocket Type)	2300	Set	15.06.2026

Note: (1) Interested tenderers may visit the website irops.gov.in for Full details/Specification/EMD & tender cost etc. All tenderers are requested to obtain digital signatures and get them registered on above site and quote electronically only. (2) For viewing and participating in other tenders such as open tender costing below Rs. 50 Lakh, limited tenders, special limited tenders and low value tenders, please visit www.irops.gov.in

619-PS/26

THE HINDU

Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

उत्तर पश्चिम रेलवे ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

मंडल रेल प्रबंधक इंडीनियर्स, उत्तर पश्चिम रेलवे जोधपुर द्वारा भारत के राष्ट्रपति के लिये एवं उनकी ओर से ई-निविदा के माध्यम से प्रचलित नियमों के अन्तर्गत निम्नलिखित प्रयुक्तों में निविदा निम्न कार्यों के लिए क्रमानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है- ई-निविदा सूचना सं. 2026-27: 24of2026-27, कार्य का नाम व स्थान: Supplying 65 mm guage hard stone machine crushed railway track ballast in stacks and loading in to railway ballast hoppers at PARIHARA ballast depot under ADEN/Degana of Jodhpur Division, अनुमानित लागत रुपये: 84731670.00, बयाने की राशि रुपये: 1694600.00, निविदा सूचना सं. 24of2026-27 निविदा प्रस्तुत करने की तिथि 19.05.2026 को 15.00 बजे तक वेबसाइट का विवरण जहाँ पर ई-निविदा देखी व भरी जा सकती है www.irops.gov.in 633-PS/26

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY E-Tender

DRM(S&T) NWR, Ajmer on behalf of the President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. Tender No.: 1. DRM-S&T-10-2026-27, 2. DRM-S&T-11-2026-27, 3. DRM-S&T-12-2026-27, 4. DRM-S&T-13-2026-27, Name of Work: 1. Ajmer Division: Provision of S&T work in C/W Construction of RUB in lieu of LC 9, 15, 17, 38, 40 and 50 with Covering shed at these LCs for elimination in COR-UDZ section over Ajmer Division NWR, 2. Ajmer Division: Provision for reliability improvement and upkeep/sustaining of various components/parts of DAC (MSDAC) at various stations over Ajmer Division. 3. Ajmer Division:- Provision of S&T Associated work in C/W Madar - Karjoda TTR (FS+TWWS+WCMSC) -1 in 12- 111-Nos. in Ajmer Division NWR, 4. Ajmer Division-Provision of 4x48F OFC for Indigenous Train Collision Avoidance System over All Division of NWR (568.24 R kms) (Umbrella Work 2024-25). Approximate cost of work: 1. Rs. 9451711.55, 2. Rs. 21752585.65, 3. Rs. 18435142.90, 4. Rs. 409040063.27. Bid security: 1. Rs. 189000.00, 2. Rs. 435100.00, 3. Rs 368700.00, 4. Rs 8180800.00. Date & Time of opening E-Tender- 25.05.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. The details of above E-Tender are available on website www.irops.gov.in 624-PS/26

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

DEATH

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

"Forever ... Together"

Mr.R.MASILAMONI (Retd. DCAO - TNHB) 06-06-1938 to 02-05-2001

Mrs.BEULAH MASILAMONI (Retd. HM - SINGARAM PILLAI GHSS) 03-03-1940 to 21-04-2021

Gone from our Presence... But, always in our Heart...

Fondly remembered by Radhika - Raveen - Suresh John - Sujitha & Family. Ph:95000 29340

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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2 Timothy 4:7 - "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."

With deep sorrow, we announce the passing of **Santhosh Varughese, (11.01.1971 – 30.04.2026)** S/o Late Mr Abraham Varghese & Late Mrs A.C.Saramma (Thiruvathilil family) His mortal remains will be at New No 25 Old No 1669, Nedyath Cottage, 15th Main Road, Anna Nagar, Chennai 600040 - for viewing from 12.30pm onwards on 03.05.2026 -Funeral services will begin at the above address at 2pm, May 3, 2026, Sunday -Service will resume in Jerusalem Mar Thomas Syrian Church, Anna Nagar, Chennai, at 3pm -Final rites at the Kilpauk Cemetery at 4 pm Phone: +91 9884092825/ +91 8015128275

Smt. Shanti Rangarajan 26 June 1934 – 27 April 2026 Sri-vaikunta-prapti on the auspicious day of Ekadashi, in shukla-paksha, uttarayana . She led a fulfilled life of devotion and prayer, undertaking numerous pilgrimages (including 27 Badrinath yatras). Although widely travelled in India and abroad, she was steadfast to tradition. A woman of grace, discipline, and resilience. On her final day, after her bath and prayers, she partook of a simple meal and passed peacefully. She touched many lives with her warmth, generosity, and hospitality. She is lovingly remembered by her children Mala, Anu, Bharath, and Deeptha as well as her extended family.

DEATH

Rest in Peace

VENUGOPAL MENEN 15th March 1963 - 1st May 2026 It is with deep sorrow that we announce the passing of our beloved Venu Sir on May 1st, 2026.

The funeral will be held on May 2nd, 3 PM onwards from his residence.

Your prayers and support means a great deal to our family. +91 99627 17126 / 89395 28068

DEATH

5th Anniversary

K.S.Natarajan (14-01-1948 - 2-May-2021)

Chairman - Gandhi Seva Sangham, Dindigul Manager - CESC Organs, Nagapattinam Ex-Secretary - TN Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, Madurai Ex-Member - Central Gandhi Smarak Nidhi, New Delhi Ex-Correspondent - Gandhi Centenary Memorial School, Coimbatore

We miss you everyday Veethiammal N, Krishna Kumar N & Aruna V, Sarojini N & Kumaran Karthikeyan K, Samyukta.K, Mithravana.K, Mughlikarthik.K Mobile: 9500860088

Mrs. ASHA VIJAYARAGHAVAN RETD. JUDICIAL MEMBER, ITAT, W/o Mr.R.VIJAYARAGHAVAN D/o Mr.K.R.RAMAMANI - Mrs. HEMALATA RAMAMANI DEEPLY MOURNED BY R. Vijayaraghavan, Mridula, Vikram, and Family Members Staff and Advocates - SAPR Advocates Staff RMT SCHOOL Last Rites on 3rd May 2026 (Sunday) at 9.00 AM New No:75A, Old No:105A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, Mylapore, Chennai - 4. Mobile : 98402 96186

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

11TH ANNIVERSARY

PREMA RAJAGOPAL (Retd. DCAO - TNHB) 02-05-2015 "You are always with us" Fondly remembered by K. Rajagopal, Meenakshi & Raghu Sudha & Praveen, Radhika & Gopinath and Grandchildren.

15TH DEATH ANNIVERSARY IN FOND MEMORY OF

J.K. RAAGUL (a) Kiran B.E.(ECE) DOB: 10.09.1992 - DOD: 02.05.2011 Ever Living in Our Hearts We deeply miss your love and care Your unfortunate Parents R.Jayakumar & Sangeetha Jayakumar 98405 55999

Helplines for students writing NEET

Contact telemental health service at 14416 or State's health helpline 104 for free counselling

Dos and Don'ts

Tips for students preparing to write the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test on May 3

Take short breaks while studying

Avoid using mobile phones and watching television as much as possible. Instead, take short walks or talk to parents or friends

Eat easily digestible food. Avoid eating outside food to prevent gastritis

Be prepared with whatever is required for the examination a day ahead

Read the instructions for the exams and follow them

Reach the examination centre ahead of time

Avoid last-minute conversations or discussions on portions covered to prevent stress

Parents should avoid stressing their children and provide emotional support instead. Take them for a walk or talk to them

Drink adequate water

Getting good sleep is vital

Revise your lessons

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) for admission to medical courses scheduled to be held on May 3, students and parents in need of counselling can contact the toll-free telemental health service at 14416 (Natpudan Ungalodu) or 104, the State's health helpline for tele-counselling.

To protect the mental well-being of students, the State government was continuously providing tele-counselling services through its Natpudan Ungalodu initiative.

Those requiring counselling services can contact the phone numbers without hesitation.

The service is available round the clock through trained counsellors and doctors, a press release said.

Residents complain of poor air quality, health issues due to illegal garbage burning

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Residents of Semmanchery and Perumbakkam have raised concerns over the persistent illegal garbage burning in a marshy area behind the Perumbakkam bus depot and the apartment complex nearby.

Residents complained that thick smoke from the burning garbage had engulfed the neighbouring areas. This resulted in poor air quality and breathing difficulties. It also emitted a persistent foul smell, particularly at night.

Harsha Koda of the Federation of OMR Residents' Associations (FOMRRA) said the dumping was illegal as the site was not designated for the purpose. It was located in close proximity to educational institutions, a private hospital, and an upcoming multi-specialty hospital.

Ananta, who resides in the complex, posted pictures of the burning garbage on his social media handles on Thursday.

Ananta said, "The burning continued on Friday [May 1]. Experts have warned about the severe environmental impact of burning waste on marshlands, including water contamination and destruction of sensitive ecosystems."

Medical waste
Residents also claim that medical waste was being incinerated alongside regular



Source of worry: Residents of Semmanchery and Perumbakkam raise concern about the persistent burning of garbage in a marshy area behind the Perumbakkam bus depot. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The illegal dumping site is close to an apartment complex and educational institutions

garbage, as discarded masks were recently spotted at the location.

'GCC not involved'
An official from the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) clarified that the civic body was not involved in the dumping and that the plot belonged to the Perumbakkam panchayat.

An executive engineer with the Tamil Nadu Urban Habitat Development

Board tenements in the locality said the garbage was being burnt by workers of the panchayat on their designated revenue land near the graveyard.

Panchayat yet to act
"We formally wrote to the panchayat two to three months ago, requesting it to remove the garbage dumped. However, no action was taken. Officials said they were engaged in election work and that was the reason for the delay," he said.

Since the Model Code of Conduct is in force, the panchayat representatives could not give an official reply, the official added.

THE HINDU
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Timings CHENNAI		
SATURDAY, MAY. 02		
RISE	05:48	SET 18:24
RISE	19:01	SET 05:53
SUNDAY, MAY. 03		
RISE	05:48	SET 18:24
RISE	19:53	SET 06:36
MONDAY, MAY. 04		
RISE	05:48	SET 18:25
RISE	20:45	SET 07:23

ADMISSION NOTICE

Common Entrance Test-2026 F for Admission at

INSTITUTE	COURSES
 Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya National Institute for Persons with Physical Disabilities (Divyangjan) (PDUNIPPD) 4, Vishnu Digamber Marg, New Delhi-110002 Website: https://pdunippd.nic.in , E-mail: cetpdunippd2026@gmail.com	• BPT • BOT • BPO
 Swami Vivekanand National Institute of Rehabilitation Training and Research (DIVYANGJAN), Cuttack (SVNIRTAR) Olatpur, PO- Bairoi, Cuttack, Odisha - 754010 Website: https://svnirtar.nic.in , E-mail: nirtar@nic.in	• BPT • BOT • BPO • BASLP
 National Institute for Locomotor Disabilities (DIVYANGJAN), Kolkata (NILD) B.T. Road, Bonhooghly, Kolkata -700090 website : https://nild.nic.in , E-mail : nild@nic.in	• BPT • BOT • BPO • BASLP
 National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Multiple Disabilities (DIVYANGJAN), Chennai (NIEPMD) East Coast Road, Muttukadu, Kovalam Post Chennai-603112, Website: www.niepmd.tn.nic.in , E-mail: niepmd@gmail.com	• BPT • BOT • BASLP
 Ali Yavar Jung National Institute of Speech & Hearing Disabilities (Divyangjan), Mumbai (AYJNISHD) K.C. Marg, Bandra (W) Reclamation Mumbai - 400 050 Website: http://ayjnishd.nic.in , E-mail: ayjnishh-mum@nic.in	• BASLP
 Composite Regional Centre, Secunderabad Manovikas Nagar, Bowenpally, Secunderabad, Telangana-500009.	• BASLP
 Composite Regional Centre for Skill Development, Rehabilitation & Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities, (DIVYANGJAN), Guwahati (CRCSRE) Guwahati Medical College Hospital Campus Post Office Indrapur, GMC Hospital Rd, Bhangaagarh, Guwahati, Assam-781032 Website: creguwahati.nic.in	• BASLP
 Composite Regional Centre, Patna Sheikhpura, (Old Dharamshala), Near Nursing College, Patna-800014 Website: https://crcpatna.nic.in , E-mail : crcpatna@rediffmail.com	• BPO

Starting date of online publication of Information Brochure & App
Closing date of online receipt of Application form
Date of Entrance Test
For Details Log On to pdunippd.nic.in

All Concerned may please note

Director, PDUNIPPD, New Delhi

cbc 38103/12/0001/2627

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INBRIEF



IPS officer C.V. Anand takes charge as Telangana DGP

Senior IPS officer C.V. Anand on Friday assumed charge as the Telangana Director General of Police, succeeding B. Shivadhar Reddy, who retired from service on April 30. Mr. Anand spent the first nine years of his service in Naxal-affected districts, where he personally led operations and participated in anti-Naxal action. Since then, he had held several key positions in the police department.

Kerala probe panel gives IPS officer Sujith Das a clean chit

IPS officer Sujith Das has been reportedly given a clean chit by an inquiry committee constituted by Kerala Police in connection with the controversial phone call case involving former Nilambur MLA P.V. Anvar. Mr. Das had been suspended from service in September 2024 when he was serving as the District Police Chief (Pathanamthitta), shortly after Mr. Anvar publicly released audio clips and made disclosures alleging misconduct by the officer.

Six killed, one injured in road accident in Hyderabad

Six persons, including three minors, were killed and a woman injured after their car rammed a lorry on the Outer Ring Road near Thondupally village in Shamshabad mandal in Hyderabad on Friday evening. The accident was reported around 4:50 p.m. near the exit number 16 of the ORR. The family was travelling back home from Yadadri Swarangiri temple. Shamshabad police registered a case and further investigation is under way.

Burglars drill into jewellery shop, flee with valuables worth a crore

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Burglars drilled through the wall of a jewellery store in northwest Bengaluru earlier this week and made away with valuables worth approximately ₹1.2 crore. The incident unfolded on the intervening night of April 27 and 28 at R.B. Jewellers, located in a complex in Havanur Layout near Hesaraghatta Main Road.

No security at night
The complainant stated that the shop was securely closed on the night of April 27, around 9.15 p.m., and that security guard arrangements were in place only during the morning hours. The burglary came to light early the next morning. Around 7.30 a.m., the owner of the complex alerted the complainant that the rear wall of his store had been drilled. Upon inspection, the complainant found that the burglars had also broken into an adjacent shop belonging to a person named Madhusudhan. After entering his shop, the accused had drilled through the wall to gain access to the jewellery store. Once inside, the accused reportedly made away with silver articles weighing around 70 kg. In addition, electronic items including a laptop, a mobile phone, and a digital video recorder were stolen. The accused also took silver items worth approximately ₹50,000 and cash amounting to ₹1,500. The total value of the stolen items is around ₹1.2 crore.

Karnataka launches official portal to assist gig workers

They can lodge complaints on pay, working conditions and other disputes on the portal; these grievances will be automatically routed to aggregators for settlement; govt. to monitor the process

Shilpa Elizabeth
BENGALURU

In a move to secure the rights of the growing platform-based labour force, the Karnataka government has officially operationalised a specialised grievance redressal mechanism for platform-based gig workers. The mechanism, a first of its kind in India, has been developed by the Karnataka Platform-based Gig Workers' Board in collaboration with the Department of e-Governance.

Ensuring transparency
With the new mechanism coming into force, gig workers can now officially lodge grievances, including regarding pay, working conditions, and platform-



The gig workforce has so far operated without a formal or legal dispute resolution framework. FILE PHOTO

specific disputes, through the Integrated Public Grievance Redressal System (IPGRS) portal. This creates a formal bridge between the lakhs of gig workers in Karnataka and the technology aggregators they serve. This is expected to bring transparency and legal recourse for a workforce that has so

far operated without a formal dispute resolution framework. **Committees mandatory**
Under the Karnataka Platform-Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act and Rules, every aggregator platform must constitute an internal dispute resolution committee

(IDRC). Grievances filed on the IPGRS will be automatically routed to the respective platform's IDRC to be addressed and settled within a strictly defined timeframe. The government will act as a central facilitator, monitoring the process to ensure a smooth and transparent flow of communication between workers and platforms. So far, details of 12 lakh active gig workers have been shared by platforms, according to G. Manjunath, Additional Labour Commissioner and CEO of the Board. Schemes for gig workers, depending on the platform they are working for, are also being worked out and will be placed for deliberation in the next board meeting.

Two killed in Kerala as elephants brought for temple fests run amok

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

A 40-year-old man was killed and another man injured after a captive elephant ran amok near the Mahavishnu Temple at Kidangoor, Angamaly in Kerala on Friday.

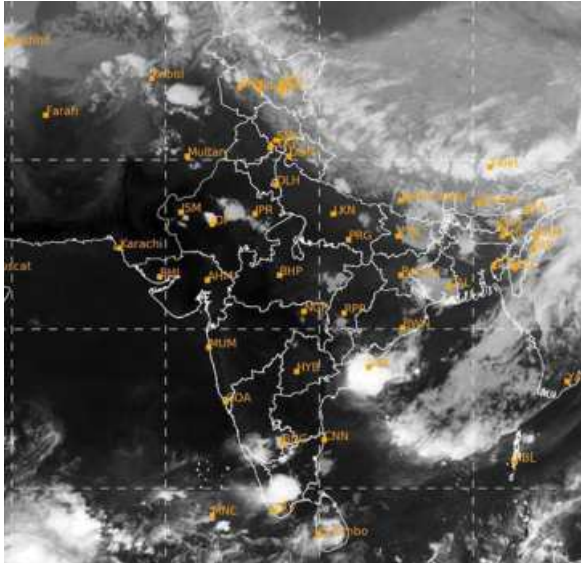
In a similar case, an elephant brought for the annual festival at Koodalmanikyam temple, Irinjalakuda, Kerala, turned violent and killed one of its mahouts and injured another on Friday afternoon. The deceased in Kidangoor is Kollam-native, Vishnu, the driver of the lorry which transported the elephant. The mahout of the elephant, Pradeep, has been hospitalised with injuries. The elephant, brought from Kollam for a

festival at a nearby temple, Mayyanad Parthasarathy, flipped a vehicles parked on the premises of the temple and damaged a compound wall, spreading panic in the area. The deceased in Irinjalakuda identified as Sreekruttan, 25. Elephant Vazhva-di Kashinathan, turned violent around noon and attacked its two mahouts, Amal, 28 and Sreekruttan.

Though both were rushed to hospital, Sreekruttan succumbed to his injuries. Eyewitnesses said the elephant trampled Sreekruttan, causing severe chest injuries. Amal is currently undergoing treatment. According to reports, the elephant had shown signs of aggression on Thursday night as well and attacked two persons with its trunk.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Saturday: Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Kerala, Mahe, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal. Heavy to very Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, West Bengal and Sikkim.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		2.0		25.8		22.9	
Ahmedabad		0.0		43.3		27.4	
Aizawl		0.4		24.3		18.1	
Allahabad		2.0		35.7		22.4	
Bengaluru		1.0		34.4		21.0	
Bhopal				32.8		18.4	
Bhubaneswar		0.0		35.2		19.8	
Chandigarh		0.7		30.3		28.8	
Chennai		0.0		37.4		25.2	
Coimbatore				30.3		28.8	
Dehradun				17.1		12.4	
Gangtok				34.8		27.5	
Goa				36.6		20.0	
Guwahati				40.2		27.0	
Hubballi				21.2		16.4	
Hyderabad				40.0		21.2	
Imphal				33.2		24.6	
Jaipur				23		108	
Kochi				22		19	
Kolkata				61		122	
Kozhikode				23		36	
Kurnool				11		24	
Lucknow				15		30	
Madurai				31		78	
Mangaluru				17		32	
Mumbai				8		35	
Mysuru				36		51	
New Delhi				18		13	
Patna				23		108	
Port Blair				22		19	
Puducherry				61		122	
Pune				23		36	
Raipur				11		24	
Ranchi				15		30	
Shillong				31		78	
Shimla				17		32	
Srinagar				8		35	
Thiruvananthapuram				36		51	
Tiruchi				18		13	
Vijayawada				23		108	
Visakhapatnam				22		19	

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		56		34		61	
Bengaluru		10		23		36	
Chennai		15		11		24	
Delhi		31		24		78	
Hyderabad		17		16		32	
Kolkata		8		35		9	
Lucknow		36		51		56	
Mumbai		18		13		24	
Pune		23		108		35	
Visakhapatnam		13		29		22	

Pollutants in the air you are breathing
In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Chhapra, Bihar recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 308 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 14

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)
Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Harvest rescue



After rain: Farm workers dry harvested paddy after sudden downpour at Nunna near Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh, on Friday. K.V.S. GIRI

Facility manager quits job in Bengaluru, turns barren land into self-sustainable green farms

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

Solthadi Nanda Kishore Nayak was employed as a facility manager in a tech firm in Bengaluru for 18 years. During COVID-19, he decided to return to his native village of Polali in Dakshina Kannada district of Karnataka, leaving desk jobs to take up farming on a land that belonged to his parents, but was left uncultivated. "I never considered agriculture as a career because it did not seem profitable. But during the lockdown, when people rushed to stock up on food, I realised how essential farming is for our survival,"



Nanda Kishore invested over ₹40 lakh to transform the seven acres barren land into a thriving farm in less than five years.

said the 55-year-old, standing in his field. "I turned to organic farming." On his land, which is in Kariyangala Gram Panchayat in Bantwal taluk, Mr. Nayak has adopted multi-cropping pattern

and an innovative technique to earn a steady income from seven acres of what was once barren. Drawing on nearly two decades of experience in both private and public sectors, he transformed

the seven acres of sloping, rugged, barren land into a thriving farm in less than five years. He invested over ₹40 lakh, sourced from his gratuity and provident fund, towards land development and irrigation. "I have planted around 3,200 arecanut saplings, 125 coconut trees, 400 banana plants, 300 cocoa plants, 100 sandalwood, 75 red sandalwood, and about 70 varieties of fruit-bearing plants to ensure income throughout the year," he said. Mr. Nayak currently earn about ₹7 to ₹8 lakh a year, spends around ₹1 lakh a month on maintenance and says that the income is expected to rise

significantly as the areca and coconut trees are yet to start yielding fully. Noting the growing demand for organic produce, he added that traders from nearby towns regularly visit his farm to buy tender coconut, banana, and breadfruit. Mr. Nayak has adopted intercropping, growing multiple crops together. The mix of commercial and fruit crops- with different growth cycles and root systems- helps maximise land use and maintain soil moisture for most of the year, he said. The farm now attracts regular visits from farmers to learn about organic and multi-crop farming.

Under-performing MLAs won't be renominated, says Naidu

The Hindu Bureau
PAMIDIMUKKALA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Friday, launched a blistering attack against the Opposition, accusing it of pursuing destructive politics, while asserting that only performance-driven leadership would have a place in his government. Addressing a public meeting in connection with the May Day and 'Pedala Sevalo' programmes at Pamidimukkala, Andhra Pradesh (Krishna district), Mr. Naidu made it clear that under-performing MLAs would not be renominated. "I will directly seek feedback from the people. Those who fail to deliver will not get another

chance," he warned, signalling a strong stand on accountability. Terming the NDA a force of "reconstruction," Mr. Naidu said Andhra Pradesh was witnessing a renewed phase of development. Striking a chord with the residents, Mr. Naidu highlighted Krishna district's importance in the State's growth story, noting that it ranked among the top regions for development and revenue generation. **Key infra projects**
Emphasising infrastructure expansion, the Chief Minister pointed to rapid development in the Vijayawada-Machilipatnam corridor. Key projects, including the six-laning of the Machilipatnam bypass

road, expansion of the beach road, and development of a six-lane highway between Vijayawada and Machilipatnam, were progressing at a fast pace, he said, reiterating plans for an Expressway linking Hyderabad to Machilipatnam, aimed at boosting connectivity and economic growth. **'Vindictive mindset'**
Targeting the previous regime led by Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, the Chief Minister alleged that crucial projects such as the Polavaram irrigation project and Amaravati capital city were derailed owing to its "negligence and vindictive governance." He said that partially completed works too were neglected.

Kerala consumer rights activist Dijo Kappan passes away

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Social activist Dijo Kappan, 68, passed away at Pala in Kottayam district of Kerala on Friday. He breathed his last at a private hospital where he had been undergoing treatment after being injured in a car accident in October last year in Thiruvananthapuram. Kappan was known for his activism focusing on consumer rights and awareness. In 1988, he founded the Centre for Consumer Education, which aimed at protection of the rights of consumers and farmers. He had led

several legal battles in his capacity as the trustee of the centre. His notable legal interventions include on a variety of public causes such as hike in electricity charge and road tax, waste management crisis in Kochi and inconveniences caused by display of advertisement boards on public roads. He had led a prolonged battle against the hurdles in allowing insurance claims to victims of road accidents. He was also active in civil rights movements and discussions in news channels. He was the chairman of the Sabari Railway Central Action Council.



Work in progress

India must strengthen public sector hospital capacity

The 80th, and latest, round of the household social consumption (health) survey conducted by the National Statistical Office is the first comprehensive survey of its kind in both the post-pandemic era and the period in which the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) scheme attained maturity. The previous two surveys of the same kind revealed that most Indians did not have any form of health insurance. Since PMJAY’s launch in 2018, the 80th round shows that insurance coverage has expanded around threefold, accounting for an increasing share of health-care financing in hospitals. However, the hospitalisation rate has not recovered to the 2014 level, meaning that having an insurance card still does not guarantee access to a bed, and hidden costs continue to limit access. The reimbursement rates under PMJAY and State-funded insurance schemes are often below market rates, so private hospitals compensate by billing patients separately for diagnostics and ancillary services. In other words, while state-funded health insurance is subsidising private health-care providers’ access to low-income markets without also enforcing regulated prices, the combined system provides a safety net where insurance covers hospitalisation and the public network has improved financial protection for households seeking primary care. Second, the Proportion of Population Reported Ailing has doubled, while infectious diseases have declined and non-communicable diseases have increased. Economists have interpreted this as a sign of more people seeking care, thus becoming ‘visible’ to the health-care sector.

Previous surveys singled out out-of-pocket expenses (OOPE) on health care as a leading cause of poverty. In the 80th round, while the mean OOPE has roughly doubled, the median OOPE has dropped, to ₹11,285 per hospitalisation and at nearly nothing for public outpatient care. Health-care expenses in India are a mix of many low-cost consultations and a few significant and expensive interactions, such as surgeries and chronic care. The two trends thus mean that while health care is becoming more affordable, thanks to the public sector absorbing the cost of primary and secondary care, health care’s ability to inflict financial deprivation in a few cases remains high. Part of the problem is the AAM network, which provides free medicines and diagnostics, of Ayushman Bharat still being significantly underfunded relative to the needs of managing chronic diseases, and where the private sector dominates. Thus, overall, the poor have nominal coverage but are often excluded from the benefits of coverage in practice while the more insured middle class faces rising catastrophic costs. The next phase of health-care reform, after shielding care-seekers from poverty and achieving near-universal institutional delivery, will need to strengthen public sector hospital capacity to compete with the private sector for tertiary care.

Primary league

In Kerala, the UDF is engaged in ugly manoeuvres for the CM’s post

The Congress in Kerala has been counting its chickens before they hatch. For several weeks, senior leaders have been positioning for the Chief Minister’s post, assuming that the United Democratic Front (UDF) would win the Assembly elections on May 4. Just as the party sought to put a lid on the unseemly public display of personal ambition, its most important ally muddled the waters. Panakkad Sadiq Ali Shihab Thangal, State president of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), publicly backed V.D. Satheesan for Chief Minister, citing exit polls of dubious authority, and urging the Congress’s central leadership to let public sentiment guide the choice. The blowback was immediate. Sectarian leaders who have been whipping up anti-Muslim sentiment were quick to claim that the Congress and the UDF were in the IUML’s stranglehold. The charge has a history to feed on. The IUML’s maximalist demands for seats, cabinet berths and portfolios have contributed to that impression, and are at least partly linked to rising tensions between the Muslim community on the one side and Hindus and Christians on the other – a realignment that has proved beneficial for the BJP. The UDF may have barely stalled the disintegration of its social base in this election, if at all. The IUML’s public posturing is a stinging reminder of what to avoid if the Front is to remain viable in the face of rapid social change.

The conventions of Kerala’s coalition politics are clear and have held for decades. A single party rarely wins an absolute majority; the partners of a Front collectively win those numbers. The leading party – Congress in the UDF, CPI-M in the LDF – elects its legislature party leader, who is then accepted by the Front as Chief Minister. There is no record of that decorum being broken by any junior partner in either Front. Neither Front contested this election with a declared chief ministerial candidate; even the sitting Chief Minister, Pinarayi Vijayan, was not named as the LDF’s CM candidate. In both Fronts, the Chief Minister has emerged through a two-step process involving newly elected MLAs and the central leadership of the party concerned. In the UDF and LDF, popular leaders have often missed the top post simply because there are always multiple contenders but only one post. The IUML would serve itself, the culture of coalition politics and the social fabric of Kerala far better by respecting that decorum. The Congress high command, for its part, must demonstrate that manoeuvres that embarrass the party carry a cost, not a reward.

Philosopher John Locke tellingly argued that “things of this world are in so constant a flux, that nothing remains long in the same state”. Seemingly localised events such as the French Revolution, the two world wars, the collapse of the Soviet Union, the September 11 attacks and Lehman Brothers’ crash all kickstarted profound global disruptions. The 2008 financial crisis unleashed socio-economic pressures that heralded a tsunami of populist-autocrats leading right-wing parties (henceforth the Right). As evidenced by contemporary global upheavals (the conflict in West Asia being just the tip of the iceberg), this tsunami is the single biggest threat to the liberal world order.

Most analyses focus on the ‘what’ of this phenomenon, namely that the Right is fashioning a neo-conservative world order – where nations have spheres-of-influence and might is right; are culturally pure (code for xenophobia and racism); and where the liberal world order’s norms are vilified as impediments to a mythical golden period. Other analyses outline the similarities in the Right’s domestic politics or how it embeds undemocratic and atavistic norms in the new world order they are forging. What is understudied is how the Right breathes life into its shared goals and why it acts like it does.

In deciphering the how, the Right has colluded to establish an “international ideological axis” over decades. Networks such as the International Democracy Union, the Movement, the National Conservatism Conference, the Conservative Political Action Conference, the Heritage Foundation (whose Project 2025 United States President Donald Trump is scrupulously unleashing globally) either train parties on manufacturing consent, create networking opportunities for right-wing politicians, frame coordinated responses on global issues, and weaponise their respective diasporas to support populist-autocrats. Through these, the Right has unleashed undemocratic upsurges against progressive values and parties, as well as the liberal world order. It is no coincidence that 91 countries representing 72% of the world’s population are classified as autocratic by the Varieties of Democracy Institute.

A global right alignment

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)’s role in this counter-hegemonic project is illustrative. Having effected a gleichschaltung on the Indian state, the BJP has redeployed the nation’s foreign policy systems to help redraw the global map ideologically. As outlined in a recent book, *India’s Tryst with the World*, Indian missions are bypassed as the BJP’s ideological outposts (the Hindu Swayamsevak Sangh or HSS, the Overseas Friends of BJP and other Sangh Parivar affiliates) map and harass liberal academics working on India, obfuscate the targeting of foreign citizens (highlighted in a 2024 Canadian Security Intelligence Service report) and support the Right as part of an ideological internationalism.

Evidence of boots-on-the-ground collaboration can be found in the Operation Dharmic-Vote campaign in the 2019 British general election, which saw the Overseas Friends of BJP campaigning for Conservative Party candidates in



Salman Khurshid

Former Minister for External Affairs



Pushparaj Deshpande

Director, Samruddha Bharat Foundation

The Bharatiya Janata Party’s collusion with the global right hurts India

48 constituencies. Similarly, the ‘Howdy Modi’ and ‘Namaste Trump’ rallies stumped for Mr. Trump, as did Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s pre-Operation Roaring Lion visit, which politically endorsed Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu ahead of Israel’s national elections.

Likewise, exorbitant funds are channelised for extremist causes (a 2022 report by Jasa Macher found that just seven Sangh Parivar affiliates in the United States spent over \$158.9 million on right-wing causes). Some of this has yielded results, as democratic regressions in France, Germany, the Netherlands, the United Kingdom, and the U.S. testify.

Although this evokes a perverse epicaricacy among some in India, the BJP’s Janus-visage lies bare abroad. Belying efforts to project Mr. Modi as a Gandhian *vikas-purush*, the BJP’s role in this international axis has sparked deep unease.

First, transparency groups have alleged that the Prime Minister’s personalised diplomacy transcends collusion with populist-autocrats, and furthers the interests of crony-capitalists (who support the BJP’s politico-ideological objectives).

Second, progressive parties increasingly perceive the BJP’s ideological internationalism as arming the Right in their respective nations. For example, as a *Daily Mail* report alleged, the BJP’s involvement in fomenting tensions in Leicester vitiated politics and tried to strengthen the Right. Likewise, BJP delegations actively courting far-right parties across Europe has sparked deep unease among global progressives.

Third, the BJP’s ideological adventurism has triggered diplomatic reprisals (including the expulsion of Indian intelligence officials from various nations – a historic first).

Fourth, hate speech and racist attacks on Indian students abroad has mushroomed, while restrictions to visas for skilled Indian immigrants have escalated. Both suggest that the BJP-enamoured-diaspora’s efforts to ingratiate themselves with the Right yield no returns.

Finally, the BJP’s adventurism has also compromised India’s national interests. For example, by condoning kidnappings and assassinations of heads of state, wilfully ignoring the conversion of India’s strategic backyard into a conflict-theatre, circumscribing India’s historical support for a two-state solution and peace (because of an iron-alliance with Mr. Netanyahu’s Likud party) and tacitly sanctioning coercive unilateralism in West Asia and South America, the BJP has undermined India’s case on Pakistan Occupied Kashmir while imposing massive geo-economic and geo-political costs on India (as the adverse impacts of the war in West Asia prove).

The response to India’s reticence

The world reads India’s reticence under the BJP government as an abdication of India’s moral leadership of the Global South, and not responsible statecraft. Contrary to Jawaharlal Nehru’s principled internationalism (which successive Indian governments continued), in doing nothing to mitigate conflicts between NATO/Ukraine-Russia, or America/Israel-Iran, or on the Palestine issue, the BJP government is tacitly conceding that nations can violently force hemispheric hegemonies, which is why few

nations condemned China’s aggression in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh, or Pakistan after Operation Sindoor (2025).

This brings us to why the Right is dismantling the liberal world order. Focusing on the domestic to illustrate the point, even though the BJP blithely continues India’s long-standing efforts to forge a multipolar world, it is primarily striving to inscribe itself into a global conservative cartography (partly because of its ideological proclivities, and partly because it mistakenly buys into its self-propagated synonymity with the nation-state). The reason why the BJP’s covert support for the dismantling of the rules-based world order (evocatively wrapped in decolonisation rhetoric) has traction is because of the injustices of the neoliberal world order – dealt with in the article in this daily, “Navigating the global economic transformation”, October 16, 2025. After all, the Global North’s economic colonialism (including structural adjustments, capital accumulation, cheap labour, environmental colonisation and trickle-down economics), and ruthless pursuit of national interests (including through sanctions and tariffs) predate the Right.

Similarly, the Global North’s liberal incrementalism on overhauling international institutions (a *sine qua non* for India and the Global South) and inertia (despite conflicts afflicting five continents, there has not been a substantive United Nations Peacekeeping operation since 2014) has made the attack on transnational institutions seem kosher. Likewise, the Global North’s promotion of cloud-capitalism has not only exacerbated socio-cultural fault-lines, but inevitably rewarded populist-autocrats.

Ironically then, it is the “progressive” establishment’s standpattism that has paved the way for the Right. If progressives are to reclaim the centre, they must cut the self-created Gordian knot and shed familiar comforts. This means restoring confidence in shared futures, accommodating rising powers, honouring historical grievances, rewriting the geo-economic norms underpinning the world order, and reimagining multilateral institutions.

What the fightback must entail

Given the polycrisis engulfing us, progressives must shed their Macbeth-like fog of nostalgia, bureaucratic hesitation and technocratic chimeras. Eschewing liberal echo-chambers, progressives should mould new value-aligned partnerships with each other (especially between the Global-North and Global-South parties) and non-political stakeholders. This necessitates new institutional arrangements (like what Spain’s Global Progressive Mobilisation and India’s Bharat Summit promise) that allow structured dialogues between evangelical accelerators from all nations (which the Non-Alignment Movement once was). This means exerting unprecedented political will, and recalibrating operational methodologies (such as the recent Hungary, Poland and New York campaigns) to sway the silent majority more effectively than the Right. Only then can we weave multiple national visions into a global symphony, and put democracy back on track.

Abu Dhabi exits OPEC for an ascent of ‘peak oil’



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador with an interest in West Asia and oil matters

production to absorb the global oil glut; it resists Abu Dhabi’s pressure for a larger OPEC quota. The UAE’s ambitious plans for a post-oil advanced technologies-based economy require mega-investments in Artificial Intelligence, and data centres, ironically, requiring higher oil revenues.

War’s impact

Over the long run, Emirati strategists believe that global oil demand is approaching a “Peak Oil” moment after which crude requirement and unit value would begin their decline. Consequently, they wish to sell as much oil as possible before the “Peak Oil”. They contend that the Iran war brings “Peak Oil” even closer by causing an unsustainable surge in oil prices, destroying the demand and accelerating the shift towards alternative fuels. In the short run, the UAE wishes to take advantage of the current higher oil prices. With the 1.5 mbpd Abu Dhabi (Habshan)-Fujairah oil pipeline already operational outside the Strait of Hormuz, the UAE is well placed to do so. By quitting OPEC, Abu Dhabi has unfettered itself from any quota restrictions in anticipation of a scramble among the Gulf exporters for greater market share once the two blockades on the Strait of Hormuz are lifted.

The Emirati statement conspicuously omits the Gulf geopolitics, the 640-pound gorilla in the room. Iran hurled over 2,200 drones and missiles at the UAE during the war as retribution for its strategic ties with Israel. Separately, during the past decade, the barely concealed political and economic rivalry between Saudi Arabia and the UAE has reached a crescendo. It is hardly coincidental that the UAE’s OPEC exit announcement was timed with the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) Consultative Summit,

in Jeddah, on the Iran war, where the UAE was under-represented by its Foreign Minister. The move was widely interpreted as Abu Dhabi flaunting its regional autonomy of action to the GCC states and Iran. By ditching OPEC, the UAE, apparently, aims to steal a march over Iran and Saudi Arabia, both OPEC members, for Asia’s very large and thirsty crude markets. The move may also favour U.S. President Donald Trump, who desperately needs lower oil prices before the mid-term Congressional elections. At a wider ambit, this may be the opening overture of the UAE openly pursuing a more nationalistic foreign policy. Most observers believe that the exit of the UAE, OPEC’s third-largest producer, would not derail the cartel, although its grip on the global market would slip further below that of independent producers, such as the U.S., Canada, Brazil, and Norway. For some, the departure of the UAE, the fifth member to leave OPEC since 2016 and the biggest producer so far, may even mark the beginning of the end for OPEC.

An opportunity for India

While the Emiratis have their reasons for quitting OPEC, consumers in India, the world’s third-largest and fastest-growing crude importer, would see it with tentative hope for lower pump prices. India enjoys strategic ties with the UAE, its third-largest trading partner and fourth-largest crude supplier. To anchor the hydrocarbon relationship with the “OPEC-free” UAE, India may propose strategic joint investments in Indian downstream projects.

For the past half a century, the OPEC dictates often made Indians shudder and issue a “May Day!” call. Thanks to the UAE quitting the producer cartel, this May could have a different ring.

The UAE’s exit marks a potential turning point for global oil governance

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Iran war and U.S. line

The U.S. administration’s claim that the war on Iran has already ended is one that would perhaps allow the White House to circumvent the requirement of Congressional approval

under the War Powers Resolution, which constrains the President’s military powers. Obviously, such a process would have raised serious questions about the reckless and dangerous

misadventure that the U.S. began on February 28. It is important that nations come together to persuade all three — the U.S., Iran, and Israel — to eschew the path of violence. Deeply regrettable in all this is the

UN’s virtual absence. **Angara Venkata Giri**ja Kumar, Chennai

Vaping incident

The recent incident of vaping during the IPL 2026 season is alarming, and the

BCCI’s response of imposing a mere fine is inadequate. The IPL commands a vast audience, including impressionable youth, and an incident such as this risks normalising harmful behaviour. Accountability

must go beyond token punishment to uphold discipline and responsibility. **Nagarajamani M.V.**, Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



Sanjay Sharma, editor of 4pm News on YouTube, recording a video for his channel at a makeshift studio in Mumbai. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Far from a safe harbour

An infrastructure of censorship is emerging, enabling the Central and various State governments to take social media content down using existing laws and rules. Independent media outlets and online critics now find their reach at a precipice. **Aroon Deep** reports on how in an environment of misinformation and deepfakes, opposing voices also become targets

Six months after the Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh in 2017, in which the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) achieved a landslide victory, Sanjay Sharma, the editor of an evening newspaper in Lucknow, was summoned by a senior official close to the Chief Minister's Office.

"The officer told me, 'The Chief Minister is very upset with you; he thinks you are Akhilesh's man,'" said Sharma, referring to Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, who was Chief Minister of the State from 2012 to 2017. He was recounting the episode over Zoom at a public policy event in April 2026.

Responding to the officer's allegation, Sharma showed him a series of articles published in 4PM News, the evening newspaper he edited, scrutinising the previous government led by Yadav.

The officer was not convinced. Sharma said the officer asked him to change at least the front page of the newspaper on a regular basis, since politicians from the Opposition were highlighting portions of what the paper had published.

Sharma said he refused. This decision allegedly came at a cost. His State press accreditation, which gave him access to subsidised housing and a host of other benefits, was not renewed. He was compelled to move houses.

In 2018, even as he continued as editor of 4PM News, he decided to start a YouTube channel of the same name, anchoring most of the videos himself. "I didn't know that a new world awaited me," he said at the policy event. In the eight years that followed, his follower count increased to over 8 million, far from the reach of the Uttar Pradesh police. He had found a national audience.

However, during the India-Pakistan conflict last year, Sharma ran into trouble again for his videos on Operation Sindoor. The 4 PM News channel was blocked in India by a government order. He approached the Supreme Court, which remarked that blocking was a "chilling assault on journalistic independence". The government withdrew the order.

In March, the 4PM News channel was blocked in India again. This time, the government defended its decision in the Delhi High Court, accusing Sharma of spreading "conspiracy theories" around the Pahalgalam attack and 4PM News of being a "foreign influence infrastructure".

A problem across States

Sharma is not alone. Over the last few months, across States, several YouTube videos, Facebook posts, Instagram reels, and posts on X have gone missing and so have entire accounts that posted them. Those affected include individual users, at least one political party, independent journalists, and online news outlets.

In Kerala this March, police sent notices to many users for sharing images of an Election Commission document with a BJP seal. The document and seal were real, but the Commission later said it was just a party annexure that was mistakenly included in an official reply.

These kinds of takedowns make you think twice about posting about the government.

SANDEEP SINGH
Activist

In Tamil Nadu last year, the police issued notices for posts on X by BJP party and politicians' accounts about the National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET), and also for a cartoon by an All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-associated news account, according to an affidavit made by X in the Karnataka High Court.

West Bengal, too, has issued notices under Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000, on content about Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. In Punjab, the Press Di Azaadi Bahal Karo Sangharsh Committee Punjab (Committee for the Struggle to Restore Press Freedom) described growing number of notices against independent media by the Aam Aadmi Party-led government in the State.

Gone in a jiffy

On March 18, 2026, multiple accounts were removed from X and Instagram. The Hindu counted dozens of such posts in a review of takedown orders posted by affected users, but comprehensive statistics are not available, as these orders are confidential. Many of the accounts were critical of Prime Minister Narendra Modi or mocked him. One such reel, made by the comedian, Pulkit Mani, mimicked Modi's mannerisms while interacting with foreign dignitaries. While the takedown triggered the Streisand effect, as Opposition politicians and content creators such as Dhruv Rathee reposted it, that did not stop more censorship from following.

DrNimoYadav, an anti-establishment handle on X with over 1.3 lakh followers, was censored the same day; so were Nehr who? (2.4 lakh followers) and ActivistSandeep (1.2 lakh followers). Some of the owners of these accounts complained about the ban from other handles, while some accounts had such a large number of fol-

lowers that their absence was noticed.

Sandeep Singh, who runs ActivistSandeep, lives in Delhi. "I am a Dalit activist, and a lot of my activity is on the ground. I have been posting about it on social media since 2018," Singh says. His following – 1.2 lakh followers on X and 7 lakh subscribers on YouTube – did not contribute much by way of revenue, he adds. He has also done public relations and campaigning work for Nitin Raut, a Congress leader in Maharashtra.

On the night of March 18, Singh got an email from X, informing him that his account had been withheld in India under Section 69A of the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000, which allows the Indian government to block public access to online information in the interest of India's sovereignty, defense, security, friendly relations with foreign states, or public order. He had received no warning and no copy of the legal order. There was no way of finding out what he had posted that had led to his account being blocked.

Singh contacted the Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF) advocacy group in Delhi, which has been helping people with cases such as his. IFF lawyers approached the Delhi High Court for Singh, DrNimoYadav, and Nehr who? The latter two were compelled to disclose their real names in the process. On April 6, after receiving a list of the actual posts that had led to the expulsion, the court ordered that their accounts be unfrozen.

On April 13, Singh was granted a post-decision hearing at the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology. "There were 11 officers there," he says, many of them from the Indian Administrative Service. Some of the senior-most officers allegedly grilled the activist on why he invoked the Prime Minister's name so often. Singh says he declined to take down the posts and will continue to challenge the government in court.

The rules that govern speech online

The IT (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021 established a framework for social media intermediaries and streaming platforms in India. They govern a concept known as 'safe harbour' under which social media platforms are generally exempt from legal action in court, including criminal proceedings against their employees, as long as they take down content when they receive "actual knowledge" of "illegal content". The Shreya Singhal v. Union of India case (2015) had narrowed down "actual knowledge" to mean a court order or a Section 69A order.

Over the years, the IT Rules have created an alternative interpretation that is yet to be tested fully by the legal system: actual knowledge could be a message from the government or from authorised police officers around the country. Ignoring

such communication could mean loss of safe harbour. The IFF, in a filing with the United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights, argued that the IT Rules' use for take-downs is improper.

These concerns became more immediate in February this year, when an amendment reduced the deadline for removing unlawful content to secure safe harbour protection from 36 hours to three. In April, it turned out that those concerns came true for Meta. As The Hindu reported, the Facebook and Instagram parent now immediately takes down content referred to it under Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, which removes 'safe harbour' immunity for intermediaries if they fail to expeditiously remove unlawful content after receiving actual knowledge or a government notification.

However, not all firms have reacted the same way. A review by The Hindu of takedown notices sent to X shows that while the firm notifies users, it continues to only act on a narrow slice of Section 79(3)(b) notices, something the government flagged in submissions with the Delhi High Court.

The Union government had created the Sahyog portal under the Ministry of Home Affairs in 2014 for the rapid removal of unlawful content. This has taken a larger role in online content governance in recent months. Within a year, over 1 lakh pieces of content were flagged by the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) alone. It is unclear how many were taken down. The government does not disclose blocking orders. Social media platforms disclose government takedown orders in bulk on a biannual basis. The extent of takedowns on Meta's platforms will only be known well into the second half of this year.

While the Union government is in charge of amending the IT Rules, its use as a takedown mechanism is far from restricted to the IT Ministry and the I4C. There is growing usage of Section 79(3)(b) in non-NDA-led States, such as Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Punjab and Kerala, where police have over the last few months not only used the Sahyog portal to issue takedown notices, but also separately contacted social media platforms directly with such communications.

India has always provided broad exceptions to freedom of expression under Article 19(2) of the Constitution. These restrictions are extensive, covering anything that may affect the "sovereignty and integrity of India, the security of the State, friendly relations with foreign states, public order, decency or morality," as well as matters involving contempt of court, defamation, or incitement to an offence.

The IT Act has long had a procedure for forcing "intermediaries", such as internet service providers, and later social media platforms, to take down content. These blocking rules, largely under Section 69A, allow the government to block content that falls within a subset of Article 19(2) exemptions.

The IT Rules, 2009, mandate a committee to review each blocking request made by designated officers and provide the affected party a chance to be heard. IT Ministry officials have argued in recent years that time is of essence on social media, and that quickly taking down "illegal content" is appropriate. One official quoted the maxim, "Lies go around the world before the truth has put on its shoes."

Choice of targets

The choice of targets so far – critics and media outlets – largely "follows a template," said Susan Koshy, an assistant professor at the Department of Media Studies, GITAM School of Humanities and Social Sciences, Hyderabad. "They target the fringe elements before going for the main guys. Even when they go after political people, there is some material based on which they pursue them," she said.

Some of the pushback has not been as fierce in the past: "There is a certain exhaustion which sets in," she conceded. "But there are memes in response to the censorship that are a positive aspect," she said, referring to online reactions to some viral instances of takedowns.

Platforms, on their part, are not keen on emphasising user rights, but they are voicing concerns. "Let me begin by saying that we are not doubting the intention of the government," Vertika Misra, director of public policy at Nasscom, whose members include Google and Meta, said on April 30 in a small online discussion held over Zoom with tech policy speakers from the industry. "There are duplications, there is ambiguity, and there is a great deal of confusion regarding the obligations being introduced."

She was referring to a new batch of amendments to the IT Rules, which propose making guidelines issued by the IT Ministry "binding" on platforms. "If the government keeps coming up with these amendments and regulations on a regular basis, how do you plan your systems and how do you cater to such large volumes of user-generated content in real time?"

When asked at a press conference in March about accounts being taken down on a large scale, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw denied such actions. "A huge quantity of deepfakes has started coming in the social media world. And the world and social media platforms have ramped up their efforts in removing deepfakes. Platforms themselves have doubled or tripled their own takedowns, which are basically deepfake takedowns. It is a new menace and a new threat for the society," he said.

Rajneil Kamath, vice president at the Trusted Information Alliance, a group of fact-checkers which debunks deepfakes, does not buy this argument. Speaking during a small discussion, Kamath said, "The word deepfakes in many ways is being used as a blanket term to describe any content that you don't like, and that becomes a pretext for content being taken down."

Singh said that social media was the only space left with unfiltered criticism of the government. "This kind of takedown makes you think twice about posting about the government," he said.



Activist Sandeep Singh during an interview in New Delhi. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

CM
YK

INBRIEF



Noida airport to start flights on June 15 after CEO change

Noida International Airport will commence commercial flight operations from June 15 after appointing an Indian CEO, following the security regulator’s refusal to grant clearance to its previous Swiss chief, which had delayed the airport’s launch. The airport said the start date follows the ‘receipt of approval for its Aerodrome Security Programme (ASP) from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), certifying that its security framework, systems and operating procedures meet regulatory requirements for commercial operations,’ according to a press statement. Last week, the airport appointed its chief financial officer, Nitu Samra, as interim CEO after the BCAS denied security clearance to Christoph Schnellmann, a Swiss national who was earlier heading the project.

‘Govt. to sustain capex push despite fiscal stress on war’

The government will proceed with the planned ₹12.22 lakh crore capital expenditure in the current fiscal to maintain the growth momentum despite the fiscal stress arising from the ongoing West Asia conflict, a senior official said on Friday. Expenditure Secretary V. Vualnam said the upcoming few quarters and the coming year would possibly have a “lot of stress points”. Tax buoyancy could be impacted by a cut in excise duties on petrol and diesel brought about in late March. “The fiscal stress is indeed very much a reality, but at the same time... the capex would really be a priority item, which we would like to preserve and ensure that it continues at the budgeted level,” Mr. Vualnam said at the ICPP Growth Conference here. He said highways, railways, shipping, ports and urban development sectors would be the focus areas for FY27 capex. India’s fiscal prudence has put it on a good stead in these unpredictable times, he added.

How prediction markets are making their way into top newsrooms



Risk laden: Gannon Ken Van Dyke ‘used classified information’ to win money on Polymarket. AP

NEWS ANALYSIS

Mohamed Yunuss
CHENNAI

Major news publishers such as CNBC, CNN, Fox News, have struck deals with prediction market platforms recently. While the platforms operate by betting on various topics, including sports, finance, science, and culture, the question of why they sign deals with news outlets looms large.

Deal goals unclear

The two largest prediction market platforms, Polymarket and Kalshi, say that their media partnerships are a boon for journalism. However, the deals’ details and goals are unclear. “The world of finance depends on real-world outcomes, Kalshi predicts those outcomes,” said Kalshi CEO Tarek Mansour after signing a deal with CNBC in December, 2025.

According to Bernstein Research, prediction markets are expected to grow up to \$1 trillion by 2030. U.S. President Donald Trump’s Truth Social has also announced its own

prediction platform: Truth Predict, which is yet to be released publicly.

Sports gambling and sports news outlets have long co-existed even before the boom of major prediction market platforms.

Danny Funt, the author of Everybody Loses: The Tumultuous Rise of American Sports Gambling, told *The Hindu*, “In the U.S., many news outlets are fighting for survival, or at least facing difficult financial times. Under those circumstances, it is difficult to decline a potential new revenue stream, and these prediction market platforms certainly have a lot of money to spend.”

He said that it’s advantageous for these companies to be promoted on big news platforms. “These partnerships typically require news outlets to incorporate references to prediction markets in their coverage, which legitimises prediction markets and gives them more visibility.”

“These partnerships will likely motivate journalists to go out of their way to reference prediction markets, even when it doesn’t necessarily benefit their

coverage. Worse, it might silence journalists, who’d otherwise be inclined to cover negative aspects of it,” he added.

Inherent risks

Apart from this, experts suggest that people who have access to confidential information may buy cheap shares in that outcome when market probability is low.

When the news officially breaks, the probability and share price skyrocket, allowing insiders to cash out for massive profit.

On April 23, a U.S. special forces soldier involved in the military operation to capture Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro was charged with using classified information about the mission to win more than \$400,000 in Polymarket.

“It is very important that journalists are seen as serving their audience, looking out for their best interests. Promoting gambling potentially undermines that commitment, especially at a time when gambling problems are surging in the U.S., and people are already losing faith in the media,” Mr. Funt added.

More flight cuts loom at Air India amid cost pressures

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

After implementing a 10-12% cut on international flights in April and May, Air India (AI) is preparing for further cuts in June and July amid soaring fuel prices and longer flight paths that have raised operating costs and impacted profitability.

“The airspace and ATF price situation are extremely challenging, leaving us with no choice but to further trim schedules for June and July,” AI CEO Campbell Wilson told staff.

This, he said, was on top of cuts enforced for April and May as many international flights had “become unprofitable to operate”.

Airline and government sources said cancellations were to the tune of 10-12%. But domestic flights were not impacted thus far, said AI sources. AI operates 1,100 international and domestic flights daily. AI sources said the carrier had not withdrawn from any destination but cut frequencies on select routes.

Services to San Francisco, New York, Toronto, Vancouver and parts of Europe, including Copenhagen, Paris and Zurich have seen some curtailment, while routes to London, Milan, Vienna and Amsterdam remain unaffected.

Though AI maintains no cuts had been effected for domestic flights, the CEO said its profitability too had “been significantly affected, but to a lower degree” as the government limited the hike in ATF prices from April 1 to 25% even as international flights saw a 100% rise. AI posted a wider-than-expected annual loss exceeding ₹22,000 crore for FY26, as per reports.

Auto firms’ wholesales surge in April

Most automakers reported a double-digit growth and lower inventory, indicating sustained demand despite the West Asia conflict; Maruti Suzuki India Ltd., the country’s biggest passenger car maker, sold 2,39,646 units, the highest-ever monthly sales volume, increasing 33% year-on-year

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Passenger car sales continued to gain momentum in April backed by the velocity created by the September cut in GST rates. Most automakers reported a double-digit growth and lower inventory, indicating sustained demand despite the West Asia conflict.

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd., the country’s biggest passenger car maker, sold 2,39,646 units, the highest-ever monthly sales volume, up 33% year-on-year. Domestic sales touched an all-time high of 1,91,122



In fast lane: Maruti Suzuki Ertiga cars parked at the company’s plant in Manesar, Haryana. REUTERS

units, up 35%.

Backed by a reduction in the GST rate, sales of small cars, attracting 18% duty, skyrocketed. The firm’s mini segment, com-

prising Alto and S-presso, reported sales of 16,066 units, up 154%.

The sales to other OEM slid 14% to 8,470 units from 9,827 units a year ago while

Maruti sales to other OEMs slid 14% to 8,470 units while exports stood at 40,054, up 44%

exports stood at 40,054, up 44%.

Tata sales rise 31%

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd. reported domestic and international sales at 59,701 units, up 31%. This includes sales of Tata Passenger Electric Mobility Ltd., a subsidiary of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd.

Mahindra & Mahindra

Ltd. (M&M) said the overall auto sales stood at 94,627 vehicles, up 14%.

In the Utility Vehicles segment, the firm sold 56,331 vehicles in the domestic market, a growth of 8% and overall, 57,833 vehicles, including exports. The domestic sales of commercial vehicles stood at 23,427 units, up 7%.

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. achieved monthly domestic sales of 51,902 units in April, up 17%. HML logged monthly export sales of 13,708 units.

Toyota Kirloskar Motor (TKM) said it sold 32,086 units, reflecting a growth of 17% compared with

27,329 units sold in April 2025. This includes 30,159 units sold in the local market and 1,927 in exports.

Kia India for the month of April reported wholesale volumes of 27,286 units, marking a 16% year-on-year growth over 23,623 units sold in April 2025.

JSW MG Motor India registered a 3% YoY growth clocking 6,018 in wholesales during the month.

Nissan Motor India Pvt. Ltd. recorded 75% growth in sales at 5,388 units. The firm recorded total sales of 5,388 units, including 3,203 units in the domestic market and 2,185 units through exports.

Review of pharma, medical devices’ supply-chain resilience on cards

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

India is undertaking an assessment of the industrial supply chain resilience and manufacturing capabilities of the pharmaceutical and medical devices sector.

It is a crucial exercise and the Supply Chain Division of the Department of Commerce is behind this, pharmaceutical exporters body Pharmexcil informed members, seeking inputs.

The information provided will play a crucial role in identifying critical supply chain dependencies and in

The assessment assumes significance in the backdrop of India’s plans to boost local manufacturing

shaping policy steps to boost local domestic manufacturing in the pharmaceutical and medical devices sector, Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council of India Director General Raja Bhanu said.

Sector-specific inputs from industry experts and stakeholders is sought in Pharmexcil’s question-

naire. Production capacity and utilisation; supply chain dependencies and disruptions; import vulnerabilities and logistics risks are some of them.

The respondents have been asked about key constraints impacting manufacturing competitiveness; challenges around staff availability, skills and productivity; costs, pricing pressures and global price fluctuations; regulatory issues and policy impacts.

Information on market conditions, competition, and domestic ecosystem gaps as well as the business

outlook, expansion plans and support needed from government, especially the factors that can help raise investment in local production and biggest challenges in manufacturing are other aspects on which Pharmexcil has sought inputs from its members.

The assessment assumes significance in the backdrop of India’s plans to ramp up domestic manufacturing, through the PLI or the production-linked incentive scheme and reduce dependence on imports ever since the COVID-19 pandemic.

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TACTICAL TALK

‘Wanted to keep Dube and Brevis for the middle phase against GT’



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

‘We’ve been experimenting a little bit. We’d like to be stable now and then use the Impact Player towards the end of an innings. In the last match [against GT], our idea was to have Brevis and Dube come in the middle phase. And that’s why Sarfaraz came in after those two early wickets — CSK batting coach Hussey.

FITNESS CHECK

Let’s see how Rohit feels and what the medical team tells us: MI coach



FILE PHOTO: VIJAY SONEJI

Rohit Sharma is progressing well. We are assessing him on a daily basis with the medical team. We’ll see how he feels and pulls up. We’ll make a decision tomorrow (Saturday). Let’s see how he feels and what the medical team tells us — MI head coach Mahela Jayawardene on Rohit’s participation against CSK.

LATEST ADDITION

Sunrisers name teen all-rounder Ambrish as a replacement for Mavi



FILE PHOTO

Sunrisers Hyderabad on Friday picked R.S. Ambrish as an injury replacement for Shivam Mavi for the remainder of IPL 2026. The 18-year-old was part of the triumphant India under-19 squad at the World Cup earlier this year. Ambrish, who is a right-arm medium pacer and a left-handed batter, will join SRH for ₹30 lakh.

MATURE RESPONSE

My score and innings don’t matter if we lose: Royals skipper Parag



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

‘We could’ve bowled way better in the middle phase. We conceded a lot of boundaries in a single over, and that repeated. Hopefully, my injury is not too serious. I don’t think I need to answer any critics. At the end of the day, my job is to get two points. My score and innings don’t matter if we lose — RR captain Riyan Parag.

Lakshya, Ayush power India into the semifinals

Satwiksairaj-Chirag duo pulls off a crucial win in the commanding show against Taiwan; the 2022 champion is now assured of a medal



Never-say-die attitude: Lakshya saved two match points to prevail over Chou. GETTY IMAGES

THOMAS CUP

Press Trust of India
HORSENS (DENMARK)

Lakshya Sen saved two match points to beat World No. 6 Chou Tien Chen, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty added a gritty doubles win, before Ayush Shetty delivered the final blow as India registered a 3-0 victory over Taiwan to storm into the semifinals of the Thomas Cup on Friday.

Lakshya, who was trailing for the better part of the contest, showed remarkable resilience to script an 18-21, 22-20, 21-17 victory in a marathon clash.

World No. 4 Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty defeated Chiu

Hsiang Chieh and Wang Chi-Lin 23-21, 19-21, 21-12 to put India 2-0 ahead.

The onus then was on Ayush, and the youngster delivered.

The 20-year-old, who recently reached the final of the Badminton Asia Championships, produced a breathtaking display.

He registered a 21-16, 21-17 win over World No. 8 and reigning All England champion Lin Chun-Yi in the second singles match to seal the contest.

India, the 2022 champion, will face either France or Japan in the semifinals. The victory also assured India a medal in the prestigious event.

Earlier, with the head-to-head locked at 4-4, Lakshya and Chou engaged in another absorb-

ing duel marked by long rallies and intense momentum swings.

Chou displayed his experience in the opening game, recovering from 10-15 down and overturning a late deficit to take the lead.

Lakshya, however, responded under pressure. Trailing 13-17, the Indian reeled off four straight points to draw level.

Chou earned two match points, but Lakshya held his nerve, saving both before closing out the game to force a decider.

The results:
Quarterfinal: India bt Taiwan 3-0 (Lakshya Sen bt Chou Tien Chen 18-21, 22-20, 21-17; Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty bt Chiu Hsiang Chieh and Wang Chi-Lin 23-21, 19-21, 21-12; Ayush Shetty bt Lin Chun-Yi 21-16, 21-17).

Rahul, Nissanka keep DC’s hopes alive

IPL-19

P.K. Ajith Kumar
JAIPUR

Delhi Capitals has experienced cricket’s much celebrated glorious uncertainties.

Axar Patel’s men scored more than 260, and still managed to lose. In the very next match, they were dismissed for 75.

Capitals chased down a target of 226 without fuss, on Friday night against Rajasthan Royals at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium, posting a badly-needed win — with seven wickets and five balls to spare — to stay in contention in IPL 2026.

An opening-wicket stand of 110 off 57 balls between K.L. Rahul and Pathum Nissanka ensured Capitals’ chase was on the right track. An unbroken fourth-wicket stand of 49 between Tristan Stubbs and Ashutosh Sharma finished off the job for Capitals.

The tone was set by Nissanka as the Sri Lankan justified the faith put in him by his team. A one-bounce boundary over mid-on was followed right up by a lovely wristy flick for six against Jofra Archer in the opening over.

Rahul (75, 40b, 6x4, 5x6) also produced some delectable sixes. The partnership came to an end when Nissanka (62, 33b, 6x4, 3x6) was trapped in front, while reverse-sweeping Ravindra Jadeja.

Earlier, Riyan Parag (90, 50b, 8x4, 5x6) played a captain’s knock, after Royals lost both their inform openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Suryavanshi within the first two overs. Suryavanshi was yorked by Kyle Jamieson, who appeared to have gi-



Highlights: Rahul and Nissanka added 110 for the opening wicket after Starc scalped three in his first match of the season to restrict Royals to 225 for six. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

ven his much shorter victim something of a stare.

The Kiwi could do well to remember how the wunderkind replied to Sunrisers Hyderabad’s Pra-

ful Hinge. Before that, Mitchell Starc, playing his first game of the season, removed Jaiswal, who was undone by the pace of a full toss and skied a return

catch. The stage was set for Parag, whose previous best from nine innings this season was 29.

And he came to this match a day after being

SCOREBOARD

RAJASTHAN ROYALS
Yashasvi Jaiswal c & b Starc 6 (3b, 1x6), Vaibhav Suryavanshi b Jamieson 4 (2b, 1x4), Dhruv Jurel c Stubbs b Axar 42 (30b, 4x4, 1x6), Riyan Parag c Axar b Starc 90 (50b, 8x4, 5x6), Ravindra Jadeja c Ashutosh b Starc 20 (14b, 1x4, 1x6), Donovan Ferreira (not out) 47 (14b, 2x4, 6x6), Shubham Dubey c Ashutosh b Natarajan 6 (6b, 1x4), Jofra Archer (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (lb-3, w-6): 9; Total (for six wkts. in 20 overs): 225.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-6 (Jaiswal, 0.3 overs), 2-12 (Suryavanshi, 1.5), 3-114 (Jurel, 11.4), 4-167 (Jadeja, 16.2), 5-168 (Parag, 16.4), 6-208 (Shubham, 19.1).

CAPITALS BOWLING
Starc 4-0-40-3, Jamieson 4-0-48-1, Axar 4-0-39-1, Kuldeep 4-0-41-0, Natarajan 4-0-54-1.

DELHI CAPITALS
Pathum Nissanka lbw b Jadeja 62 (33b, 6x4, 3x6), K.L. Rahul c Ferreira b Archer 75 (40b, 6x4, 5x6), Nitish Rana c Jurel b Deshpande 33 (17b, 3x4, 2x6), Tristan Stubbs (not out) 18 (11b, 1x4, 1x6), Ashutosh Sharma (not out) 25 (15b, 4x4); Extras (b-4, lb-1, nb-1, w-7): 13; Total (for three wkts. in 19.1 overs): 226.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-110 (Nissanka, 9.3), 2-171 (Nitish, 14.3), 3-177 (Rahul, 15.2).

ROYALS BOWLING
Archer 4-0-46-1, Burger 3-0-41-0, Deshpande (**Impact Player for Shubham**) 4-0-38-1, Brijesh 3.1-0-35-0, Bishnoi 2-0-28-0, Jadeja 3-0-33-1.

Toss: Royals; **PoM:** Rahul. Capitals won by seven wickets with five balls to spare.

Next assignment

DC: May 5 vs. CSK
Delhi, 7.30 p.m.
RR: May 9 vs. GT
Jaipur, 7.30 p.m.

fined for vaping inside the dressing room.

He showed courage under fire, but it still wasn’t his night. Even Donovan Ferreira’s unbeaten 47 (14b, 2x4, 6x6) would not help.

CSK and MI in desperate need of a victory

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Whenever two of IPL’s most successful sides clash, there is a sense of anticipation and buzz unlike any other contest. It is not for nothing that a Chennai Super Kings-Mumbai Indians clash is called the ‘El Clasico’ of IPL.

They have won five titles each and dished out some of the finest games in the league’s history.

Yet, when these two franchises meet here in the reverse fixture at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium on Saturday, the conversation is more about how the mighty have fallen.

Sailing in the same boat
After eight matches, CSK and MI are in the bottom half of the table, with the Super Kings in a slightly better position, having three wins compared to just two for Hardik Pandya’s men.



Anxious faces: Suryakumar has failed to get going this season while Samson has blown hot and cold. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Chennai and Mumbai come into this fixture on the back of chastening losses to Gujarat Titans and Sunrisers Hyderabad, respectively.

The root of their struggle has been the inability to nail the right playing combination, as evidenced by the fact that Mumbai has fielded 22 players while CSK has used 19 so far.

In their previous meeting at the Wankhede Stadium, Sanju Samson’s century and Akeal Hosein’s brilliant spell in the Power-Play helped CSK hand MI its biggest defeat by runs (103) in history. The Kerala batter will once again hold the key to propping up a misfiring batting unit that struggled against GT’s pace attack at Chepauk.

Points table						
	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	8	6	1	1	13	1.043
Royal Challengers	9	6	3	0	12	1.420
Sunrisers Hyderabad	9	6	3	0	12	0.832
Rajasthan Royals	10	6	4	0	12	0.510
Gujarat Titans	9	5	4	0	10	-0.192
Delhi Capitals	9	4	5	0	8	-0.895
Chennai Super Kings	8	3	5	0	6	-0.121
Kolkata Knight Riders	8	2	5	1	5	-0.751
Mumbai Indians	8	2	6	0	4	-0.784
Lucknow Super Giants	8	2	6	0	4	-1.106

Today’s match



Chennai, 7.30 p.m.
HEAD-TO-HEAD
Played: **40**
CSK **19** | MI **21**
PREVIOUS MEETING
CSK won by 103 runs, 2026
LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIHOOTSTAR

Meanwhile, for MI, it is a question of whether it can recover from the shellac-

ing at the hands of Travis Head and Heinrich Klaasen, who made mincemeat of a 244-run target a couple of nights ago.

The visitor will hope the setback fires up the likes of Suryakumar Yadav and Jasprit Bumrah, who have had a quiet tournament.

Considering another loss could pretty much bring down the curtain on their campaign, CSK and MI fans would expect a hard-fought game befitting the storied rivalry.

‘Dhoni will return once he is confident about his calf’

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

That he would be asked to give an update on M.S. Dhoni’s availability was clear in Michael Hussey’s mind.

The Chennai Super Kings batting coach came prepared for the query, explaining that the team was “being guided” by Dhoni.

“Hopefully, he’ll be back as soon as possible. I don’t know if it’s tomorrow [Saturday] or the match after that. I know he’s been upping his running speeds, and that was the sticking point,” Hussey said at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium on Friday, on the eve of CSK’s IPL 2026 fixture against Mumbai Indians.

“We’re very confident from a skill perspective [batting and wicketkeeping], but it was just about making sure that he could maintain good running



Dhoni... the suspense continues. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

power. So as soon as he’s got the confidence in his calf, I’m sure he’ll give it the tick to be ready to go. And so we’re kind of being guided by him... we’re waiting,” Hussey said.

On Dhoni not travelling to the stadium on match-days, Hussey added:

“Yeah, he hasn’t been coming. He always wants what’s best for the team, and he was worried that if he came, there’d be a bit too much of a distraction. Whether that’s right or wrong, that’s not my decision. But that’s the thinking behind Dhoni not wanting to come to the matches.”

MI head coach Mahela Jayawardene gave an honest assessment of the season so far (four points in eight games).

“It’s not about pointing fingers at the batting or bowling group. It’s just a combination of us not being able to play consistent cricket... I don’t think anyone is shying away from the challenge, but execution sometimes fails them. It’s not on purpose; it just happens in sport. I’m not giving excuses, and we need to be better,” he explained.

INBRIEF



Taking Green Jacket to India was cool experience: McIlroy

Masters champion Rory McIlroy said the biggest memory from the past year was taking the Green Jacket to India. “One of the coolest experiences for me was being able to bring the Green Jacket to India. It was the first time a Green Jacket has ever been in that country. And I did an event with Sachin Tendulkar, which was absolutely incredible. Just to think about Sachin, cricket, the reach that it has in that country... We talk about growing golf, and a real way to grow the game is to be able to have these collaborations with other sports stars in other countries,” said the Irishman at the Laureus Sports Awards.



Japanese tennis star Nishikori to retire at the end of season

Kei Nishikori, one of Asia’s most decorated men’s tennis player, on Friday said that he will retire at the end of the season after a career ravaged by injury. The 36-year-old became the first Japanese player to reach a Grand Slam final at the 2014 US Open, eventually losing to Croatia’s Marin Cilic. He was the first Japanese man to climb into the top-10 in the ATP world rankings, reaching a career high of No. 4, and won 12 titles on tour. Nishikori also won bronze in the men’s singles event at the 2016 Rio Olympics.

Infantino confirms Iran will play WC games in the US

The FIFA president Gianni Infantino reiterated that Iran will play its World Cup games in the United States as scheduled. “Let me start by confirming straightaway that Iran will be participating at the FIFA World Cup 2026...and of course, Iran will play [in] the United States,” he said in Vancouver. Infantino’s remarks drew swift support from US President Donald Trump, who said he was “OK” with Iran’s participation. Iranian officials had floated the idea of shifting the team’s group games to Mexico, but the proposal had been nixed by Infantino.

Wood’s penalty gives Forest the advantage

Nottingham Forest’s Chris Wood smashed a penalty into the top corner to secure a 1-0 win over Aston Villa in the first leg of the all-English Europa League semifinal on Thursday.

The results (semifinal, first leg): Braga 2 (Tiknaz 8, Dorgeles 90+2) bt Freiburg 1 (Grifo 16); Nottingham Forest 1 (Wood 71-pen) bt Aston Villa 0.

ISL: Jamshedpur gets past Goa, jumps to top spot

Jamshedpur FC scored a 2-0 win over FC Goa in the ISL at Jamshedpur on Friday. Rei Tachikawa drew first blood in the 83rd minute. Madih Talal made it 2-0 in the fifth minute of added time. JFC jumped to the top spot with 21 points from 11 games while Goa slipped to third (19 from 11).



Salah ‘deserves big send-off’, says Liverpool coach Slot

Liverpool manager Arne Slot said Mohamed Salah “deserves a big send-off” and added he was expecting the departing superstar to return from injury before the end of the season. “We expect him to be back in the final part of the season, but not for Sunday,” Slot said on Friday. “It’s a big relief that his injury is minor, so that he’s able to play for us, that he’s able to play at the World Cup. And if there’s ever a player who deserves to get a big send-off, it’s definitely Mo.”



Figuring it out: Coach Muzumdar and captain Harmanpreet handed opportunities to several untested players during the recent South Africa tour. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

India squad for T20 World Cup to be picked today

The shortest format has remained a work in progress for the Women in Blue; youngsters like Anushka and Vaishnavi have staked their claim

CRICKET

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

India will name its squad for the ICC Women’s T20 World Cup – to be held in England from June 12 to July 5 – on Saturday, with Amita Sharma-chaired selection committee facing its toughest test so far.

It comes at an interesting juncture. India enters the tournament as reigning ODI World Cup champion, having ended a long wait for a global title at home last November. But in the shortest format, the journey has been less convincing.

T20Is have remained a work in progress in the post-pandemic phase. The Women in Blue India lost to eventual champion Aus-

tralia in the semifinals of the 2023 edition and failed to make the last-four stage in the following year.

The recent results reflect inconsistency. Since the ODI triumph, India swept Sri Lanka 5-0 at home in December, followed it up with a 2-1 series win in Australia earlier this year, but then slipped to a 1-4 defeat in South Africa last month.

That South Africa tour could prove particularly influential. The team management used the series to experiment extensively, handing opportunities to several untested players and even resting vice-captain Smriti Mandhana for the final two T20Is.

The question now is how much of that experimentation translates into World Cup selection. Young prospects like Anushka Sharma, the pro-

missing top-order batter from Madhya Pradesh, and left-arm spinner Vaishnavi Sharma have pushed their cases during the recent outings. Considering the swinging conditions in England, pace-bowling all-rounder Bharti Fulmali was also recalled for the South African series after a long break.

Whether the selectors back youth or fall back on experience for the mega event will be closely watched.

The meeting will not be limited to the World Cup squad alone.

The committee is also set to pick teams for the upcoming away assignments against England – a three-match T20I series and a one-off Test – as well as the India-A squads for the three one-dayers and as many T20s against England-A.

Regulatory tweaks were necessary... drivers will be much happier: Button

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Formula One champion Jenson Button backed the FIA and FI’s recent decision to make tweaks to the new regulations ahead of this weekend’s Miami Grand Prix.

F1 introduced new hybrid power units for 2026, with 50% of the power coming from electric power as part of its push towards sustainability. However, the new cars have come under intense criticism from drivers who have bemoaned that they are too complex and not fun to drive.

“It always takes a little bit of time to fine-tune new regulations. I think the changes we have here will lead to a more consistent car for the drivers. They’ll have a better understanding of what it’s doing. I think they’ll be much hap-



Familiar hunting ground: Button said the Miami race would be interesting as Antonelli ‘was really fast last year’. GETTY IMAGES

pier,” said Button, the 2009 world champion.

“We want drivers to be out there having fun and enjoying themselves when they’re racing. So it plays a big part in it because when they get out of the car, and they’re unhappy, it doesn’t look great. So yes, I think fine-tuning was necessary,” he added.

Following the cancella-

tions of the Bahrain and Saudi Arabian GPs, the teams have had a five-week break since the previous round in Japan. Button feels this gap in the calendar would have given teams valuable time to assess things and expects the field to bunch up in Miami.

“I think we will see the field a bit closer this weekend, especially the top

Solanki gushes about the Holder effect for Titans

N. Sudarshan
AHMEDABAD

For the first eight games of the ongoing IPL season, Gujarat Titans lacked a cutting edge. It didn’t put up big totals and barely intimidated opponents as it oscillated between the sublime and the ordinary, winning four games and losing four.

But that was until Jason Holder arrived like a Swiss Army knife in the four-wicket victory over Royal Challengers Bengaluru on Thursday – well-rounded, adaptable and the ideal combination of form and function.

The West Indies all-rounder conceded just 29 runs from his four overs, dismissed Jitesh Sharma and Romario Shepherd, held on to fine catches to send back Rajat Patidar, Tim David and Krunal Pandya, and was involved in a nerveless 30-run partnership for the sixth wicket with Rahul Tewatia in the



Holder, AFP

156-run chase. For a top-heavy Titans outfit with an airy middle-order, the 34-year-old has given balance, security and a progressive option. So much so that GT’s director of cricket Vikram Solanki called him the “perfect storm”.

“He’s a world-class all-rounder, isn’t he?” gushed Solanki. “When we were pursuing Jason at the auction, it was with the mind to him being able to fulfil

both roles – with bat and ball. He offers us exactly that. He’s physically strong and has great reach and leverage.

“He is also bringing an added dimension – a sprinkling of stardust of being a really experienced campaigner. Often you get individuals with experience who perhaps can’t communicate well. But Jason is always willing to have conversations, with the coaching group and the young guys.”

Interestingly, Holder warmed the bench for the first six games as Titans gave an extended run to Glenn Phillips. There is little doubt that the same courtesy would have been extended to Holder, though the beefy man has struck gold in no time.

In the manic, chop-and-change world of T20 cricket, GT is an aberration. A Swiss knife, with its “guarantee for life”, seldom needs replacing too.

IPL is a massive platform: Ambrish

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

From grinding it out in Tamil Nadu first-division cricket to achieving u-19 World Cup glory, R.S. Ambrish has seen a phenomenal rise. The teenager scaled another peak on Friday when he earned his maiden IPL contract after being picked up as a replacement by Sunrisers Hyderabad.

In an exclusive interaction with *The Hindu*, the all-rounder revealed how he made the cut. The announcement came while Ambrish was on the field



Ambrish. FILE PHOTO

during a TNCA first-division match. “I got to know during a water break,” he said. For the TN youngster, the call-up is a natural progression after knocking on franchise doors. The 18-

year-old had attended trials with Chennai Super Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders, but it was the Orange Army that secured his services.

“IPL is a massive platform. I wanted to carry forward the momentum from the World Cup and reach a bigger stage,” Ambrish said. “It feels good to be part of an IPL team. I’ll try to learn from experienced players and absorb as much as possible. My dad is my coach, and I called him right after the day’s play (in the first-division game). We discussed what I need to do next,” he said.

AROUND THE CITY



All smiles: Besant Nagar Club ‘A’, winner of the Sanmar-TNTA 45+ A-zone crown. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Ajitesh’s ton propels Globe Trotters

G. Ajitesh (107 batting, 144b, 12x4) and his 162-run unbroken sixth-wicket stand with V. Shavin (61 batting, 162b, 5x4) enabled Globe Trotters end the first day of the TNCA first division Qualifier 2 at 297 for five against Jolly Rovers here on Friday.

The scores: Globe Trotters 297/5 in 89 overs (S. Radhakrishnan 72, G. Ajitesh 107 batting, V. Shavin 61 batting, D. Deepesh 3/46) vs. Jolly Rovers. **Toss:** Trotters.

Besant Nagar Club ‘A’ reigns supreme

Besant Nagar Club ‘A’ (BNC) defeated host Anna Nagar K Block ‘A’ 2-1 to lift the 45+ A-zone title of the 33rd Sanmar-TNTA Chennai City Club tennis league championship.

The results (final): 45+ A-zone: BNC ‘A’ bt Anna Nagar K Block ‘A’ 2-1 (Ramkumar Rajagopal & Rameez Samad bt Vijayakumar Rajasingh & Vinodkumar Ramakrishnan 7-6(2), 7-5; Uday Kumar Reddy &



G. Ajitesh (Globe Trotters, 107 batting).

Paramarthalingam Pillai bt Kamalharan & Gajapathy Venkatraman 6-2,6-3; C. Ram Prasada Reddy & Karthik Kailash lost to Karthik Iyemperumal & G. P. Balaji 2-6, 6-1, 2-6).

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: IPL, CSK vs Mumbai Indians, MAC, 7.30 p.m.; Cricket: TNCA 1 div. play-offs, Qualifier 2, Sriher vs Atththis (8 a.m.); Gojan ‘C’ (T); III div. play-offs, Qualifier 2, CPCL vs Sunder (1 p.m.), Gojan ‘C’ (T); 21st Lucas TVS-TDCA Trophy, Group-A, Wheels India Ltd. vs Ashok Leyland Velvoyalchavadi (8 a.m.), OCF Giri Nagar.

LIVE TELECAST

Bangladesh vs New Zealand: 3rd T20I, FanCode, 1.30 p.m.
ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & FanCode, 5 & 7.30 p.m.
LaLiga: FanCode, 5.30, 7.45, 10 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Sunday).
Bundesliga: Sony Sports Ten 5, 2 & LIV, 7 & 10 p.m.
Serie A: DAZN, 6.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Sunday).
Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 & 10 p.m.
IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.
Formula One: Miami GP (Sprint Race), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 9.30 p.m.; Qualifying, 1.30 a.m. (Sunday).

Samson season: Sanju eventually bends time to his will

The 31-year-old has long been considered an elite talent, but it has taken him a while to show just how exceptional he can be. Things looked bleak for him at the end of January before circumstances conspired to give him another shot at the international level. He won India the T20 World Cup and then got his new IPL team, CSK, going with two unbeaten hundreds

P.K. Ajith Kumar

The young scorer from the Kerala Cricket Association spoke of the two boys who had moved to the city from New Delhi just a couple of days earlier.

“Could you take a look at them?” Sudhir Aly asked Biju George, the SAI coach who conducted training camps at the Govt. Medical College Ground in Thiruvananthapuram and had earned a reputation for nurturing young talent.

Of course, Biju would.

The following day, the kids came with their father, a former footballer who had returned home after leaving his job with the Delhi Police for the sake of his sons’ careers in cricket.

Early impression

The coach was impressed with both. The elder was sent to Wayanad, the other end of Kerala, where the State’s under-16 camp was going on. The younger one stayed back.

Biju felt the boy was an exceptional talent. “He had a lot of time to play his shots,” the former India women’s fielding coach tells *The Hindu*. “He was lovely to watch, and had a beautiful on-drive. I knew he was special.”

Sanju Samson certainly is. Like Biju, everyone who saw him bat knew it.

It, however, took the world long to find out that he is special enough to win India a World Cup. After leading India’s chase with an unbeaten 97 in a virtual quarterfinal against the West Indies, he made 89 both in the semifinal and the final, against England and New Zealand respectively, to headline India’s memorable title defence at home in the T20 World Cup a couple of months ago.

It had indeed been a long wait for Samson to fully realise his potential. He had made his India debut way back in 2015 but couldn’t establish himself in

He was lovely to watch, and had a beautiful on-drive. I knew he was special

BIJU GEORGE
Coach



PTI

the team despite being one of the most prolific and impactful batters in IPL history. In cricket’s most glamorous tournament, he played for Rajasthan Royals for much of his career, until he moved to Chennai Super Kings this season. He has already hit two unbeaten hundreds to revive the hopes of the five-time champion after a poor start

(for him as well).

The highs of the World Cup were followed by lows at the IPL: six, seven and nine were his scores before he struck 115 not out against Delhi Capitals to give CSK its first win of the season. He already looks rather at home in Chennai; he probably left Jaipur at the right time, after 11 seasons.

In his time in Rajasthan, he had lit up the Sai Mansingh Stadium on those warm summer nights – the sun would reluctantly retreat behind the horizon only after lingering well past seven o’clock in Jaipur – with his silken, clean shots. His sixes and fours came not from brute power but more from sheer timing and a sense of placement.

Among his admirers were Brian Lara, who picked him as a future superstar, and Gautam Gambhir, who argued he should be in the Indian team. Years later, the gritty former India opener walked the talk: when he became the national coach, he got him in the team and gave him opportunities, although the decision to push him down the order to accommodate Shubman Gill

Sanju has tremendous fighting spirit. He comes back strongly from hopeless situations. He has the ability to introspect and find the answers himself. His strength lies in grit, determination and persistence

TINU YOHANNAN
Former India cricketer

STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	24	13,350	20
2	Carlos Alcaraz	22	12,960	18
3	Alexander Zverev	28	5,255	22
4	Novak Djokovic	38	4,710	17
5	Felix Auger-Aliassime	25	4,100	25
6	Ben Shelton	23	4,070	22
7	Taylor Fritz	28	3,870	23
8	Alex de Minaur	27	3,845	22
9	Lorenzo Musetti	24	3,715	23
10	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,560	24
11	Alexander Bublik	28	3,445	26
12	Andrey Rublev	28	2,630	24
13	Flavio Cobolli	23	2,600	28
14	Jiri Lehecka	24	2,540	22
15	Casper Ruud	27	2,535	21



English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Arsenal	34	22	7	5	64	26	38	73
2	Man. City	33	21	7	5	66	29	37	70
3	Man. United	34	17	10	7	60	46	14	61
4	Liverpool	34	17	7	10	57	44	13	58
5	Aston Villa	34	17	7	10	47	42	5	58
6	Brighton	34	13	11	10	48	39	9	50
7	Bournemouth	34	11	16	7	52	52	0	49
8	Chelsea	34	13	9	12	53	45	8	48
9	Brentford	34	13	9	12	49	46	3	48
10	Fulham	34	14	6	14	44	46	-2	48
11	Everton	34	13	8	13	41	41	0	47
12	Sunderland	34	12	10	12	36	45	-9	46
13	Crystal Palace	33	11	10	12	36	39	-3	43
14	Newcastle	34	12	6	16	46	50	-4	42
15	Leeds United	34	9	13	12	44	51	-7	40
16	N. Forest	34	10	9	15	41	45	-4	39
17	West Ham	34	9	9	16	42	58	-16	36
18	Tottenham	34	8	10	16	43	53	-10	34
19	Burnley	34	4	8	22	34	68	-34	20
20	Wolves	34	3	8	23	24	62	-38	17

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Inter Milan	34	25	4	5	80	31	49	79
2	Napoli	34	21	6	7	52	33	19	69
3	AC Milan	34	19	10	5	48	27	21	67
4	Juventus	34	18	10	6	57	29	28	64
5	Como	34	17	10	7	59	28	31	61
6	Roma	34	19	4	11	48	29	19	61
7	Atalanta	34	14	12	8	47	32	15	54
8	Lazio	34	12	12	10	37	33	4	48
9	Bologna	34	14	6	14	42	41	1	48
10	Sassuolo	34	13	7	14	41	44	-3	46
11	Udinese	34	12	8	14	41	46	-5	44
12	Parma	34	10	12	12	25	40	-15	42
13	Torino	34	11	8	15	39	56	-17	41
14	Genoa	34	10	9	15	40	48	-8	39
15	Fiorentina	34	8	13	13	38	45	-7	37
16	Cagliari	34	9	9	16	36	49	-13	36
17	Lecce	34	7	8	19	22	46	-24	29
18	Cremonese	34	6	10	18	26	51	-25	28
19	Verona	34	3	10	21	23	56	-33	19
20	Pisa	34	2	12	20	24	61	-37	18

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Barcelona	33	28	1	4	87	30	57	85
2	Real Madrid	33	23	5	5	68	31	37	74
3	Villarreal	33	20	5	8	59	38	21	65
4	Atletico Madrid	33	18	6	9	56	37	19	60
5	Real Betis	33	12	14	7	49	41	8	50
6	Getafe	33	13	5	15	28	34	-6	44
7	Celta Vigo	33	11	11	11	45	43	2	44
8	Real Sociedad	33	11	10	12	52	52	0	43
9	Osasuna	33	11	9	13	39	40	-1	42
10	Athletic Club	33	12	5	16	36	48	-12	41
11	Rayo Vallecano	33	9	12	13	33	41	-8	39
12	Valencia	33	10	9	14	37	48	-11	39
13	Espanyol	33	10	9	14	37	49	-12	39
14	Elche	33	9	11	13	44	50	-6	38
15	Girona	33	9	11	13	36	50	-14	38
16	Alaves	33	9	9	15	38	49	-11	36
17	Real Mallorca	33	9	8	16	41	51	-10	35
18	Sevilla	33	9	7	17	40	55	-15	34
19	Levante	33	8	9	16	37	50	-13	33
20	Real Oviedo	33	6	10	17	26	51	-25	28



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Joe Root	880	932
2	Harry Brook	857	898
3	Travis Head	853	884
4	Steve Smith	831	947
5	Kane Williamson	822	919
6	Kamindu Mendis	781	784
7	Temba Bavuma	775	806
8	Yashasvi Jaiswal	750	858
9	Saud Shakeel	734	787
10	Shubman Gill	730	807

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Daryl Mitchell	815	840
2	Virat Kohli	791	908
3	Ibrahim Zadran	756	756
4	Rohit Sharma	748	879
5	Shubman Gill	716	841
6	Babar Azam	684	894
7	Shai Hope	679	782
7	Harry Tector	679	730
9	K.L. Rahul	664	676
9	Salman Agha	664	664

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abhishek Sharma	875	931
2	Ishan Kishan	871	871
3	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
4	Phil Salt	792	881
5	Pathum Nissanka	766	796
6	Tilak Varma	742	845
7	Suryakumar Yadav	722	912
8	Jos Buttler	716	794
9	Tim Seifert	705	749
10	Dewald Brevis	702	738

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Jasprit Bumrah	879	908
2	Noman Ali	843	853
3	Mitchell Starc	838	852
4	Matt Henry	836	853
5	Pat Cummins	832	914
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Scott Boland	820	820
8	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
9	Josh Hazlewood	775	864
10	Nathan Lyon	753	812

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	705	775
2	Jofra Archer	649	682
3	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
4	Adil Rashid	629	671
5	Josh Hazlewood	626	725
6	Maheesh Theekshana	624	680
7	Kuldeep Yadav	624	757
8	Mehidy Hasan	621	722
9	Mitchell Santner	599	656
9	Adam Zampa	599	696

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Jasraj Chakaravarthy	740	818
3	Abur Ahmed	736	757
4	Adil Rashid	721	747
5	Jasprit Bumrah	702	783
6	Adam Zampa	682	746
7	Corbin Bosch	669	745
8	Matthew Forde	667	679
9	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757
10	Nathan Ellis	661	678

Top Indians ➔



Sumit Nagal
Rank 277 ▲ 15 spots



Karan Singh
Rank 420 ▲ 14 spots

Top Indians ➔



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 385 ▼ No change



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 386 ▼ No change



Sawe's 5km splits: breaking down the Kenyan's run

	Time	Split
5km	14:14	14:14
10km	28:35:00	14:21
15km	43:10:00	14:35
20km	57:21:00	14:11
25km	1:11:41	14:20
30km	1:26:03	14:22
35km	1:39:57	13:54
40km	1:53:39	13:42
42.195km	1:59:30	5:51

SOURCE: OLYMPICS.COM

Talent, training, fuel, shoes: behind Sawe's historic London sub-2

The 31-year-old Kenyan became the first man to take less than two hours to run a marathon in race conditions. What went into the shattering of a once-unapproachable barrier? And just how much faster can Sawe go?

Associated Press
Agence France-Presse

What do you eat before running the fastest marathon in history? Sabastian Sawe chose a pre-race breakfast of two slices of bread with honey, washed down with a cup of tea – a modest meal, but one that experts say fuelled him with easily digestible, fast-acting carbohydrates and sugar, hydration and a caffeine boost.

The 31-year-old Kenyan, who on Sunday became the first man to take less than two hours to run a marathon in race conditions, is assured of immortality. His feat is a first-ballot candidate for any sporting hall of fame; his breakfast has a strong case for entering the culinary wing.

Cultural significance

Sawe's shattering of the long-unapproachable two-hour barrier in London ranks alongside Roger Bannister's first sub-four-minute mile at Oxford in 1954 in terms of cultural significance. Both achievements have expanded the perception of what was thought humanly possible. For context, the first sub-2:30 marathon came in 1925 and the

I have shown that nothing is not possible. I had courage to push even when the pace was so fast. I was not bothered because I was ready for it

SABASTIAN SAWE

2:15 barrier was broken 38 years after that; at the turn of the century, the world's best time was 2:05:42, set in 1999.

Sawe's time of 1hr 59min 30 sec was an astonishing 65 seconds inside the previous best of 2:00:35 set in Chicago in 2023 by Kelvin Kiptum, whose death in a car crash in 2024 plunged Kenya into mourning. Two years later, Sawe gave his country reason to rejoice.

Incredibly, 11 seconds after the unthinkable happened, it happened again. The marathon had its second sub-two runner. Ethiopia's Yomif Kejelcha, 28, finished second in 1:59:41 on his marathon debut. (Kenyan great Eliud Kipchoge did run a marathon in under two hours in 2019, but his 1:59.40 did not make the record books, as it was a specially tailored event in favourable conditions, not a competitive race.)

Sawe's statistics were dizzying. He completed the London Marathon – on a relatively flat course on a mostly sunny day (15 degrees Celsius), ideal for running – with a negative split. The second half of his race was faster than the first. With the assistance of pacemakers in the initial kilometres, he did the first half in 60:29 and then sped up, clocking a remarkable 59:01 for the second. He av-

eraged 21.2 km per hour, or 2 minutes 49.9 seconds per kilometre. "I have shown that nothing is not possible," said Sawe. "I had courage to push even when the pace was so fast. I was not bothered because I was ready for it."

Running 42.195 kilometres – a distance that has been around since ancient times – in less than 120 minutes was once treated as a natural physiological ceiling. A marathon tests a human being's energy supply (accessing and burning 'fuel' without dropping pace), aerobic limit (maximal oxygen uptake), and biomechanical precision (running form and cadence).

Punishing intensity

So how did Sawe ace this test? The Kenyan, born in the Rift Valley Province to a father who worked as a maize farmer and raised by his grandmother in a mud-walled house, is extraordinarily talented and trains with punishing intensity.

"Definitely physiologically, Sabastian has to be a good one," said Claudio Berardelli, the Italian coach who recognised Sawe's potential and has since guided him on the path to greatness. "But all the pieces come together perfectly because of his attitude, because of his character. In 22 years I've been coaching in Kenya I thought I'd seen pretty much everything, but then Sabastian started to show me something which I thought was almost impossible."

Sawe's high-volume training at altitude in Kap-



When I started dealing with Sabastian, I immediately realised this is not just one of the best Kenyan guys. At least for my experiences, he is a different human being. An outlier

CLAUDIO BERARDELLI
Sawe's coach

sabet, Nandi County, with a strong group of athletes who push him, has contributed significantly to his progress. In London, Berardelli said his athlete had been even fitter than in Berlin in September when the late-summer heat had spoiled his previous assault on the world record.

"In the last six weeks he was averaging 200km and above a week, while the peak was 241km," said Berardelli. "I knew he was super-good for Berlin, but he couldn't express himself because of the conditions. But when I started to see him running the way he ran before London, I was like, hey, something special might come out."

While a large part of Sawe's success is a consequence of his talent and its careful nurturing, there is no doubt that he has benefited from the developments in nutrition and – to a greater degree – the technological arms race launched by shoe companies a decade ago, when they began using carbon-fibre plates and other materials to make shoes lighter and springier.

"We are in the new era of marathon running because of the shoe and proper fuelling," Berardelli said. According to the BBC, Sawe reportedly worked with a research team from a sports nutrition brand which specialises in hydrogels. He trained to absorb 90-120 grams of carbohydrates per hour during the race without feeling distress. This tops the glycogen levels up, allowing the body to use carbohydrates, rather than slower-burning fat reserves, as fuel.

The newly developed Adidas shoes Sawe wore to navigate the streets of London were the lightest in history, the first 'super shoe' to weigh under 100g. They clearly made a difference – second-placed Kejelcha was wearing them too.

The combination of thick foam in the sole, shaped with a 'drop' from heel to forefoot to keep runners 'forward' in their stride cycle, and stiff carbon in the midsoles, which store and return energy, reportedly acts as a lever and spring system.

The result is better running economy – in 'super shoes', athletes burn less energy at a given pace than in regular running shoes. There has been criticism of 'super shoes', the argument being that using them is akin to mechanical doping. World Athletics has tried to regulate the revolution, but there is no doubt that it has played a major role in the lowering of times.

Sawe's achievement will inevitably be viewed against the backdrop of an appalling series of doping cases among Kenyan athletes in the last few years. But, in a bid to allay such suspicions about his own performances, he has voluntarily subjected himself to extra drug testing. Adidas provided \$50,000 to the Athletics Integrity Unit to frequently test Sawe over a 12-month period.

That began with a reported 25 out-of-competition tests in the lead-up to Berlin in September, continuing at a similar rate as he prepared for London.

Next up: Mission 1:59?

The obvious question is whether Sawe can run even faster. Berardelli believes that his athlete could breach 1:59 on a quicker course such as Berlin or Chicago. "Sabastian hasn't reached his maximum potential. It was only his fourth marathon, if we think of long-term adaptations, which is a process requiring time, I believe Sabastian has not reached this yet," said Berardelli.

"When I started dealing with Sabastian, I immediately realised this is not just one of the best Kenyan guys. At least for my experiences, he is a different human being. An outlier."

GAME THEORY

Still chasing Marita Koch: the four-decade wait

Marita Koch's mark in the 400m, set in 1985, is the second-longest-standing individual world record in athletics. It has been the subject of some debate because Koch competed in an era when East Germany was known to be systematically doping its athletes. Koch never failed a drugs test, however, and has maintained she did nothing wrong. Last year, four decades after Koch's benchmark run, two athletes, Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone and Marileidy Paulino, went under 48 seconds. Are those performances an indication that Koch's record might finally be under threat? And could 2026 be the year?

400M (WOMEN): FASTEST TIMES			
Mark	Competitor	Venue	Date
47.60	Marita Koch	Canberra	06 Oct 1985
47.78	Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone	Tokyo	18 Sep 2025
47.98	Marileidy Paulino	Tokyo	18 Sep 2025
47.99	Jarmila Kratochvilova	Helsinki	10 Aug 1983
48.14	Salwa Eid Naser	Doha	03 Oct 2019
48.16	Marita Koch	Athina	08 Sep 1982
48.16	Marita Koch	Praha	16 Aug 1984
48.17	Marileidy Paulino	Paris	09 Aug 2024
48.19	Salwa Eid Naser	Tokyo	18 Sep 2025
48.22	Marita Koch	Stuttgart	28 Aug 1986
48.25	Marie-Jose Perec	Atlanta	29 Jul 1996
48.26	Marita Koch	Dresden	27 Jul 1984
48.27	Olga Bryzgina	Canberra	06 Oct 1985
48.29	Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone	Tokyo	16 Sep 2025
48.36	Shaunae Miller-Uibo	Tokyo	06 Aug 2021
48.37	Shaunae Miller-Uibo	Doha	03 Oct 2019
48.45	Jarmila Kratochvilova	Praha	23 Jul 1983
48.53	Salwa Eid Naser	Paris	09 Aug 2024
48.57	Nickisha Pryce	London	20 Jul 2024
48.59	Tatana Kocembova	Helsinki	10 Aug 1983



PICTURE THIS



In a bind

This photograph captures action from the women's open weight class at the 41st Empress Cup All Japan Women's Judo Championship in Yokohama. Japanese judoka consider the event one of the sport's three major competitions, along

with the Olympic Games and the World Championships. Judo, created in 1882 by Kano Jigoro, is an unarmed Japanese martial art, with an emphasis on 'randori' (free sparring) rather than 'kata' (pre-determined forms). A foundational principle of judo (Japanese for the 'gentle

way') is maximum efficient use of energy. The three basic techniques, when it is taught as a martial art or a form of self-defence, involve throwing, grappling and striking. Striking, however, is not allowed in competitive judo, where the objective is to throw an opponent forcefully onto

their backs, immobilise them with a pin, or force them to submit with a joint lock or a choke. The sport's international governing body is the International Judo Federation (IJF), with professional judoka competing on the IJF circuit. Judo was first contested at the Olympics in 1964.